

Fate's Edge

Complete Worldbook

A Gazetteer of the Known Realms

AS TOLD BY THOSE WHO LIVE THERE, BLEED THERE, AND OWE THERE

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Preface: The Ledger Bleeds

I am an Aeler Edgewalker. You call us mountain-dwellers who measure breath in silver bells and seal contracts in stone. How adorably naïve.

We don't just measure breathwe own the lungs that draw it. When a Tulkani chieftain swears an oath on his firstborn's life? That's not honourit's collateral I've already hypothecated three times over. When a Veiled Sister binds a demon to a corpse to prop up her corpse-throne? That's not terrorit's a futures contract on soul-debt, and I'm the broker who sold the short position before the ritual even began.

You see the surface as "full of problems." How quaint. Problems aren't obstaclesthey're inventory.

This book isn't a tourist's guide. It's a hit list with footnotes. I've marked the places where a well-placed bell doesn't just open a passit starts a war I've already shorted the bond market on. Where a forged seal doesn't just move a mountainit triggers a landslide I've bought mineral rights to before the first crack appeared. Where a single true story doesn't just buy a ship's loyaltyit buys the captain's silence while I sell his manifest to pirates.

You want to build journeys? Draw your cards. Set your clocks. Spend your Story Beats like they mean something. But remember: every Diamond you earn is a tooth knocked out of someone else's jaw. Every Debt you incur? I already bought it from your victim for half what you'll payand I'm collecting interest in your marrow before you finish reading this sentence.

The road isn't just a ledger. It's a butcher's block. Every gate isn't a clauseit's a throat waiting for the knife.

The Edgewalker

The Cartomancers Compass

0.1 The Ledger of the Deck

The world does not speak in words. It speaks in suits, ranks, and the spaces between. Every bridge, every bribe, every broken oath can be laid out on a table of felt and dealt from a worn deck. This is not superstition. It is method.

The regional generators in this book—from the fog-choked levees of the Mistlands (??) to the walking cities of Ngomebe (??)—all speak the same language: the language of the fifty-two-card deck. Learn to read it, and you can generate a campaign, a crossroads, or a crisis in the time it takes to shuffle.

This chapter is your key. It explains how to interpret any card drawn from any regional generator, and how to weave those interpretations into the fiction at your table. Consider it the threshold between the abstract mechanics of the draw and the living, breathing world of Fates Edge.

Every card in every generator carries the same four suit-meanings. They are the alphabet of the worlds ledger.

0.1.1 ♠: Place The Stage

Where does the scene happen? ♠ is the threshold, the landmark, the ground beneath the action. It answers: *Where are we?*

- **High rank (10A):** A major landmark—a fortress, a capital, a haunted ruin. The place has a name that echoes in local songs.
- **Mid rank (69):** A functional location—a ford, a market, a shrine. The place has a purpose and a keeper.
- **Low rank (25):** A liminal or neglected place—a crossroads, a collapsed bridge, a smugglers cove. The place is defined by what it lacks.

In the regional chapters, ♠ entries are always places. See, for example, the bridges and canals of Silkstrand (??) or the cairns and passes of Ubral (??).

0.1.2 ♥: Actor The Face

Who drives the scene? ♥ is the person, the faction, the voice that speaks. It answers: *Who is here?*

- **High rank (JA):** An elite, a ruler, a power-broker. The actor has authority and reach beyond the immediate scene.
- **Mid rank (610):** A professional, a functionary, a skilled operator. The actor has a trade and a price.

- **Low rank (25):** A commoner, an outcast, a victim. The actor needs something or has been failed by someone.

In the regional chapters, ♡ entries are always people or factions. See the merchants and spies of the Brass Coast (??) or the spirit-wardens of the Mistlands (??).

0.1.3 ♣: Pressure The Complication

What pushes back? ♣ is the storm, the debt, the knife in the dark. It answers: *What goes wrong?*

- **High rank (10A):** A catastrophe, a betrayal, an invasion. The complication changes the shape of the journey.
- **Mid rank (69):** A serious obstacle a feud, a quarantine, a broken bridge. The complication costs time, resources, or reputation.
- **Low rank (25):** A minor hazard a sudden squall, a lost token, a raised toll. The complication is a nuisance, not a disaster.

In the regional chapters, ♣ entries are always complications or threats. See the river floods and witness-cord cuts of Ayokha (??) or the market riots of Silkstrand (??).

0.1.4 ◇: Leverage The Reward

What opens the door? ◇ is the token, the writ, the secret that changes Position. It answers: *What do you gain?*

- **High rank (JA):** A major asset a noble title, a keystone charter, a general pardon. The reward reshapes the partys standing.
- **Mid rank (610):** A significant tool a pass-stone, a witness cord, a lighthouse charter. The reward solves a specific class of problem.
- **Low rank (25):** A minor advantage a bridge token, a guest-cup, a rumour. The reward grants a single use of improved Position.

In the regional chapters, ◇ entries are always rewards or leverage. See the keystone charters of Ngomebe (??) or the water-share tablets of Fhara (??).

The rank of a card from Ace (high) to 2 (low) sets the scale of its suits meaning. Use this ladder:

Rank	Narrative Weight
Ace	Legendary, campaign-altering, mythic
King/Queen/Jack	Major, faction-level, lasting consequences
107	Significant, scene-defining, costly
64	Moderate, manageable, a real cost
32	Minor, a complication but not a crisis

When a generator instructs you to set a clock by the highest rank, use this conversion:

- **25:** 4-segment clock (short, local problem)
- **610:** 6-segment clock (standard, journey-length)
- **J, Q, K:** 8-segment clock (extended, regional problem)
- **A:** 10-segment clock (epic, campaign-length)

Face cards (Jack, Queen, King) are not merely high ranks. They are *persons* with agency, personality, and often a name.

- **Jack:** An agent, a functionary, a messenger. The Jack acts on someone else's authority. They are competent but replaceable.
- **Queen:** A power in their own right. The Queen has influence, resources, and a network. They are not easily replaced.
- **King:** The ultimate authority in their domain. The King is the source of law, the peak of the hierarchy. To challenge a King is to challenge the order itself.

When a face card appears in a ♡ (actor) draw, give the NPC a name, a motive, and a quirk. When it appears in a ♠ (place) or ♣ (pressure) draw, treat it as a *personified* force: a King of Clubs might be a feud that has lasted generations; a Queen of Spades might be a bridge that remembers every toll.

An Ace is not merely the highest rank. It is a *threshold*. When an Ace appears in any draw, the Hollow takes notice. The GM gains 1 extra Story Beat (beyond any generated by 1s) to spend on a supernatural complication: a ghostly procession, a bell that rings without a clapper, a shadow that walks independently.

In regions where the Ninth Taboo is strong (see ??, ??, ??), an Ace may also trigger a specific regional omen. For example:

- In Theona (??), an Ace of ♠ might add a missing step to a bridge.
- In the Ways Between (??), an Ace of ♡ might cause a reflection to speak.
- In the Mistlands (??), an Ace of ♣ might cause a bell-line to fail.

The GM should always read an Ace as a signal to escalate the uncanny.

When you sit down to generate a scene, a journey leg, or a settlement, follow this procedure:

1. **Name the destination.** Which region? Which route? Which authority controls the gate?
2. **Shuffle and draw.** Draw cards face-up, one for each suit you need. Most generators require all four suits; some (like travel legs) may use only three.
3. **Read the ♠.** This is your place. Describe it first. Set the stage.
4. **Read the ♡.** This is your actor. Introduce them. What do they want? Why are they here?
5. **Read the ♣.** This is your pressure. Complicate the scene. What just went wrong, or what is about to?
6. **Read the ◇.** This is your leverage. What can the players gain if they succeed? Be specific.
7. **Set the clock.** Use the highest rank among the four cards to determine the size of the scene's primary clock (see ??).
8. **Interpret faces and Aces.** Give names to face cards. Apply regional Ace effects.
9. **Play to find out.** Use the generated elements as prompts, not scripts. The cards are seeds, not fences.

While the core suit meanings remain constant, each region inflects them with its own texture. A ♠ in Ecktoria ([section 2.1](#)) is a forum or a coin-house; a ♠ in the Valewood (??) is a phasing ruin or a star-road. A ♡ in the Black Banners (??) is a mercenary captain or a condotta broker; a ♡ in Ykrul (??) is a khatun or a bone-singer.

Use the regional chapters as your lexicon. When you draw a card, consult the relevant table (e.g., [section 3.1](#) for Acasia, ?? for Oshiira). The table will give you a specific entry keyed to the rank and suit. Do not invent from scratch unless the table runs out – the tables are designed to evoke the specific flavour of the region.

0.1.5 Example: A Draw in Acasia

You are running a journey through the Broken Marches ([section 3.1](#)). You draw:

♠ 7, ♥ J, ♣ 4, ♦ Q

1. ♠ 7: You consult [section 3.1](#). A 7 of Spades is Hill-Motte Fresh palisade; ditch scattered with caltrops.
2. ♥ J: You consult [section 3.1](#). A Jack of Hearts is Bride with No Dowry but a Claim Daggers in the wedding chest.
3. ♣ 4: You consult [section 3.1](#). A 4 of Clubs is Wedding Turns Ambush You are caught between two bloodlines.
4. ♦ Q: You consult [section 3.1](#). A Queen of Diamonds is Marriage Proxy From the Margravine; bind a hillking to your cause.
5. **Highest rank:** Queen (rank equivalent to King/J/Q at 8). The scenes primary clock is 8 segments: *The Feud Escalates* [8].
6. **Interpretation:** The party arrives at a hill-fort (Hill-Motte) on the eve of a wedding. The bride (Bride with No Dowry) is caught between two feuding bloodlines. The wedding turns to violence (Wedding Turns Ambush). If the party can survive the ambush and broker peace, the Margravine will grant them a Marriage Proxy a powerful tool to bind a hill-king to their cause. The 8-segment clock tracks how quickly the feud spirals into open war.

This is the generator at work: four cards, one scene, immediate fiction.

Sometimes, a generator does not require all four suits. A travel leg, for example, may only need ♠, ♥, ♣ (see ??). A social encounter might only need ♥ and ♣. When a suit is missing, treat its absence as a question:

- **No ♠:** The place is ambiguous, shifting, or hidden. The scene occurs in a liminal space a crossroads, a fog-bank, a threshold.
- **No ♥:** The actor is absent, silent, or dead. The pressure and place act without a face. This can be more frightening than a named NPC.
- **No ♣:** The scene is calm, peaceful, or mercifully straightforward. This is rare in Fates Edge. Treasure it.
- **No ♦:** The reward is not a token but an outcome. The players gain Position, information, or a cleared clock rather than a physical asset.

When you need a prompt in a hurry a random encounter, a rumour at a tavern, a discovery in a ruin draw a single card. Use this quick-reference:

♠	A place or landmark. What is its name? What happened here?
♥	A person or faction. What do they want? What do they fear?
♣	A complication or threat. Who or what is the obstacle?
♦	A reward, token, or secret. What can be gained?

The rank tells you the scale. A low rank is local and personal; a high rank is regional and political. A face card demands a name; an Ace demands the Hollows attention.

This single-card method is ideal for improvisation. It gives you one clear element to build around. Let the fiction answer the rest.

The generators in this book are tools, not tyrants. If a draw gives you an entry that contradicts established fiction, or if you simply prefer a different interpretation, overrule it. The deck is a prompt, not a prison.

But trust it, too. The most memorable sessions often come from the card you did not expect. The Ace that arrives at the wrong moment. The Jack who speaks a name no one wanted to hear. The diamond that glows with a secret debt.

Shuffle. Draw. Interpret. And let the road unfold.

The ledger is never closed. It is only passed to the next keeper. Dusana of the Raven Road

Part I

The Amaranthine Sea & Northern Shores

“The sea keeps a better ledger than any scribe. The reef remembers every secret whispered above its depths. Do not ask which flag flies highest ask which hull leaks slowest.” Dusana of the Raven Road

Chapter 1

Kahfagia

The Flag of Storms.

I was born on the tide, which is to say I was born owing. My mother was a net-mender who lost her fingers to a reef-cutter's debt. My father was a bell that is to say, he rang when the Admiralty pulled his string. I learned to read the lantern codes before I learned my letters, and I learned that every light is a lie waiting to be told.

The Admiralty runs this place like a pirate charter with a budget and oh, how they love pretending it's legitimate. They control the beacons that lure ships onto reefs, the booms that shatter hulls for salvage rights, and the tariffs that fund their champagne baths. But here's the secret the commodores don't want you to know: the lanterns are afraid of the dark too.

I've seen a Mirror-Keeper weep when her reflection showed her a daughter she'd sold for a pilot's license. I've watched a Privateer Captain kiss a silver coin before a raid the same coin her mother kissed before she never came back. This is not a city of heroes. It is a city of people who learned that the sea is cheaper than mercy.

If you want to move cargo through the straits without becoming fish food, get a convoy letter stamped with the Admiral's seal. Or get smart. Or get gone.

Captain Mira "the Lucky," Sidhi exile, pirate by convenience

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Salt fish porridgedried cod soaked overnight, boiled with hardtack and a splash of lamp oil. The oil is for calories. The fish is for memory. Every Kahfagian child learns to taste the salt and know which coast their grandmother came from.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count ships by their lanterns. Three lanterns means a Kahfagian merchantsafe. Four means an Oshiiran grain bargeneutral. One, low in the water, means a privateer. Run.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their hands. Dock-workers have rope-burned palms. Merchants have ink-stained fingers. Privateers have no fingernailsthey bite them off in storms.

What is the most common crime? False manifests. Every third ship carries cargo that doesn't appear on its papers. The Admiralty knows. The Admiralty takes a cut. The Admiralty calls it a "tariff surcharge."

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Mirror-Keepers are not bornthey are made. And the making requires a death. A sister, a daughter, a lover. Someone who drowned so the keeper could see through the fog.

Where do people go when they die? The tide takes them. Kahfagia has no cemeteries above ground. The drowned are weighted with chain and dropped in the deep channel. Their families light candles in paper boats and float them out at dusk. If the candle reaches the horizon, the soul is forgiven. If it sinks, the debt is not yet paid.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer your bell. Every Kahfagian carries a small brass bell on a leather cordthe sound of their name. Offering it to the wronged party means "I give you my voice. Speak for me." Refusing to return the bell after an apology is a declaration of blood feud.

What is the most important festival? The Beacon Lighting (midwinter). Every lighthouse keeper lights a new lamp from the Admiral's flame. If your beacon catches first, your year will be lucky. If it sputters, you will owe a death to the sea.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Admiral's lantern code has a ninth signalnever used, never spoken, burned into every keeper's memory. It means *"Kill the witnesses. Sink the evidence. The sea will hide the rest."*

1.1 Kahfagia — “The Creole Thalassocracy”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Every mirror is a blade, every beacon a promise. The sea obeys when we move the lights but the spiders weave in the mirror-towers.*

Admiral of Lantern-Law (Elite): “Every mirror is a blade, every beacon a promise. The sea obeys when we move the lights and woe to the fool who rows against them. Yet I have seen the reflection move before the hand that holds it. The tides are not the only ones with secrets.”

Dockside Factor (Commoner): “The pilots see farther than kings. A gesture in lantern-code can open ports, or close them. Keep your debts paid, and your lamps trimmed. And if a greyrobed stranger offers to adjust your mirror for free say no. The Lethaiar have long memories, and longer webs.”

Genre / Mood: Creole thalassocracy, signalandlane politics, eldritch tide, secret infiltration.

Starting Location: The Lantern Pier admiralty chapel, where votive ships hang from the ceiling and brine drips from the icon of a drowned saint. A seanotary unlocks a saltstained reliquary and produces a chart with gilt edges. “Fetch the contraband bell from the corsair galleass *Santa Dolorosa* before moonrise or the harbour names you accomplices. And watch for silk threads on the bollards. The Spider’s children are everywhere.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Kahfagia is the Creole child of Oshiira and the Vilikari a thalassocracy where Oshiiran ledgers meet Vilikari tidelaw. The Admiralty of Lantern-Law rules not by armies but by light, yet the real power flows through a tangled web of oligarchic families, each with their own spies, their own private navies, and their own seat on the Shadow Council. Above them all floats a central Admiralty fleet, charged with protecting the beacon monopoly and with watching the watchers.

But the oligarchs are not the only players. Unseen, the Lethaiar of Inaea have been infiltrating the mirrortowers for decades. A factor’s trusted secretary, a harbour master’s silent wife, a pilot’s apprentice with toostill eyes they weave their webs not for coin, but for *control*. They do not seek to destroy Kahfagia. They seek to *own* it, strand by strand, until the entire thalassocracy hums to the rhythm of the Spider’s mercy.

What you notice first: The constant chime of bell-buoys. The smell of salt, tar, and burnt oil from a thousand lanterns. The way everyone admiral to dockhand glances at the tide clock before speaking. And the faint, almost invisible silk threads tied around the bollards of the wealthiest piers.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never argue with a MirrorKeeper about where the channel lies. If they say the safe water moved, it moved. Your chart is already kindling. And if the MirrorKeeper smiles too widely, check the back of their neck for a spider’s brand.

Regional Mood: The Lantern’s Vigil & The Spider’s Web

Power is visible here literally. Every night, a thousand lamps burn along the channels, each a statement of control. To dim a light is to declare bankruptcy. To move a beacon is to declare war.

Commodores sit in their mirrortowers, watching reflections, while tideclocks tick down to the next auction, the next inspection, the next quiet murder.

But beneath the visible power, another war is fought in whispers. The Lethaiar agents of Inaea have spent a generation infiltrating the oligarchic families. A young heir who suddenly displays uncanny negotiating skill may not be talented they may be *woven*. A MirrorKeeper whose beacons never fail may be receiving guidance from a source that does not appear on any chart. The Spider's web is patient. It does not break the thalassocracy; it *guides* it.

Prominent NPCs of Kahfagia

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Admiral Zafira	Commander of Lantern-Law	Keep the beacon monopoly intact	She has never lost a ship to the reefs. Her charts are said to be drawn in water.
Mirza al-Qasr	Mirror-Keeper of the Pointe	Control the tides through light	Her face is never seen only reflected. Some say she has no shadow.
Ximena	Dockside Factor (commoner exemplar)	Profit from every cargo, legal or not	She keeps a ledger in lemon juice; heat reveals the truth.
Captain Rodrigo	Privateer with a crooked letter of marque	Raid the corsair fleet and pay off his crew	His ship flies three flags; the one he lowers last is the one that matters.
Sister Anabel	Healer of the Hospitallers of the Salted Veil (Temple of Light)	Tend the sick without asking payment	Her grey robes are said to be woven from old debts. They never stain.
Notary Farid	Admiralty magistrate	Resolve disputes before they reach the harbour master	He carries a waterclock in his sleeve to measure the shifting of legal moods.

The Harpist	Veiled	Lethaiar infiltrator (secret)	Woven the oligarchs, strand by strand	No one knows her face. She plays only in mirrorlit rooms, and her music leaves threads of silk in the listeners’ hair.
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The Oligarchic Houses (Shadow Council)

The true rulers of Kahfagia are not the Admiralty alone, but the **Shadow Council** of seven oligarchic families. Each controls a monopoly (spice, salt, silk, timber, pitch, shipbuilding, or intelligence). Each maintains its own private navy and network of spies. Each vies for the empty seat left by the family that the Lethaiar have already *woven* into silence.

- **House alKassam (Spice):** Oldest, proudest, most vulnerable. The Lethaiar have already replaced the family steward.
- **House Carrasco (Salt):** Ruthless pragmatists; they suspect infiltration but cannot prove it.
- **House Mirat (Silk):** Secret allies of the Lethaiar they trade webs for influence.
- **House del Puerto (Shipbuilding):** Neutral; they build for anyone who pays.
- **House Henares (Timber):** Deeply indebted to the Admiralty; the Lethaiar are slowly buying their notes.
- **House de la Vela (Intelligence):** The Admiralty’s own spy network and already compromised.
- **The Empty Chair:** Once held by House Morat, now vacant. The other houses whisper that the Morats were not destroyed they were *rewoven*.

Secret Faction: The Silk Vigil (Lethaiar Infiltrators)

Agents of Inaea, the Spider’s children have spent a generation worming into Kahfagia’s elite. They do not steal or sabotage they *guide*. A decision that benefits House Carrasco is subtly nudged toward the Lethaiar’s longterm goal: a unified thalassocracy that answers not to the Admiralty, but to the Web.

Signs of Infiltration:

- A factor’s handwriting becomes unnaturally precise, the loops forming faint eightshapes.
- A MirrorKeeper’s reflections show the same face in every tower a woman with chestnutbrown skin and eyes like polished jet.
- A ship that should have foundered instead limps to port, its crew speaking of a greyrobed passenger who vanished before docking.

Mechanical Hook: Once per session, a PC may roll Wits + Lore (DV 4) to notice a silken thread in an official’s collar or a spider’s brand on a dockhand’s wrist. On success, they identify a

Lethaiar agent. On failure, the agent becomes aware of their scrutiny and the Web tightens.

Names of Kahfagia

Inspired by the seafaring republics of the western coast, blended with Oshiiran and Vilikari influences: liquid consonants, soft vowels, and surnames that denote a port, a ship, or a founding ancestor.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Safir	Zafira	alKassam	<i>the Lantern</i>
Idris	Ximena	del Puerto	<i>TideKeeper</i>
Farid	Layla	de la Vela	<i>the Unlit</i>
Jabir	Aisha	Carrasco	<i>MirrorEye</i>
Rodrigo	Salma	Mirat	<i>BellBorn</i>
Tarik	Nura	Henares	<i>AshSails</i>

Spades — Places (Littoral/Lane/Law)

2. **Tidal Mudflat** — Hidden plankway at low water; smugglers' shortcut. *At ebb, the planks rise like the ribs of a drowned whale.* '[STEALTH]'
 3. **Salt-Scar Pier** — Behind dawn spice auctions; where fortunes wash ashore. *Auditors check the saltscars white crust that proves cargo was cleaned, not stolen.* '[TRADE]'
 4. **Reedbelt Creeks** — Smuggler paths where tax boats won't follow. *A hanged man's boots hang from a piling; those who pass tug their collars.* '[STEALTH]'
 5. **Breakwater Gap** — Under repair; cutters slip at dusk through the works. *The stone is still loose. A wrong step, and the sea claims another toll.* '[TRAVEL]'
 6. **Dredged Channel** — Fresh with temporary beacons; tomorrow's safe water. *The buoys are painted yellow the colour of "maybe."* '[TRAVEL]'
 7. **River Sluice** — Tidegate and boomchain; access controlled by rope and writ. *The chain has a notch where a slaver's ship tried to flee. It still drips oil.* '[AUTHORITY]'
 8. **Cutter Yard** — Narrowkeel vessels; apprentices work night shifts. *They sing old work songs the kind that skip the ninth beat.* '[LABOR]'
 9. **Lantern Alley** — Foglane where beacons migrate with the tide. *Follow the lights. Two blinks means you're expected. Three? You're prey.* '[WEATHER]'
 10. **Admiralty Quay** — Bonded warehouses under seal; law walks the decks. *The seal on the door changes with the tide. Today it's a serpent eating its tail.* '[AUTHORITY]'
- J **Red Shoal** — Quiet water, loud reputations; where deals are made. *Old barges moored together; a floating court with no bailiff.* '[SOCIAL]'
- Q **Mirror Tower** — Pilot station that certifies safe water today. *The mirror at the top shows not the sea, but the face of the last captain who argued.* '[JUSTICE]'
- K **Kassamira Port** — Presidial; auctions at dawn, courts by noon. *The auctioneer's gavel is wrapped in a page torn from a debtor's ledger.* '[TRADE]'
- A **The Pointe** — Strait of stormlights and wreckers' tales. *On still nights, you can hear the drowned singing the names of those who owe.* '[DEATH]'

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Tide-Runner** — Bell and rope; knows every tidetable by heart. *“The table says high water at noon. The moon lies. Trust my rope.”* ‘[TRAVEL]’
3. **Pilot’s Apprentice** — Perfect memory for shoals; tomorrow’s navigator. *Touches a brass talisman before every sounding. No one knows why.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
4. **Lantern Clerk** — Knows which lights moved, and why; keeper of the shifts. *Docks with a ledger that smells of smoke. Adds a surcharge for “recent adjustments.”* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
5. **Oshiiran Factor** — Two ledgers; one for Kahfagia, one for truth. *The left ledger records bribes as “conciliation fees.” The right one is never shown.* ‘[TRADE]’
6. **Dock-Syndic** — Makes queues vanish; power in the pause. *He never raises his voice. The harbour master listens anyway.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
7. **Lantern Advocate** — “Jurisdiction moves like tide”; law in flux. *She carries a waterclock in her sleeve to measure the shifting of legal moods.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
8. **Privateer Captain** — “Crooked” letter of convoy; profit in the margins. *Her ship flies three flags; the one she lowers last is the one that matters.* ‘[COMBAT]’
9. **Thalassoi Sergeant** — Shore leave but still on duty; marine precision. *A tattoo of a lighthouse on his forearm; the light is his wife’s name.* ‘[COMBAT]’
10. **Admiralty Magistrate** — Rules fast, travels faster; justice in a hurry. *She once sentenced a man to the galleys and boarded the ship before he did.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
- J **Dredging Foreman** — Channel follows their purse; water reshaped. *His crew are excriminals; he pays them in salt pork and absolution.* ‘[LABOR]’
- Q **Mirror-Keeper (Elite)** — Commodore’s confidante; places beacons that bind. *Their faces are never seen only reflected. Some say they have none.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- K **Kahfagian Commodore** — Off the books but on the water; shadow admiral. *His flagship is a fishing smack. Its nets drag up letters of marque.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- A **Admiral of Red Shoal** — Offers wine, figs once. Price in stories. *She pours the first cup herself. If she pours a second, you’ve already agreed.* ‘[LEGEND]’

Clubs — Complications/Threats

(Entries unchanged except for the addition of a new threat: **Web Unravelled** a Lethaiar agent is exposed, and the oligarchs turn on each other.)

2. **Early Tide** — Turns two bells early; grounding risk rises like the sea. ‘[WEATHER]’ *Someone bribed the tideclerk or the moon is angry.*
3. **Smothering Fog** — Sound travels, sight does not; navigation by ear alone. ‘[WEATHER]’ *You hear oars. Then you don’t. Then they’re behind you.*
4. **Boom Slam** — Harbour chain slams shut; wrong side means delay or danger. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The chain’s links are inscribed with names of debtors. Each one rattles differently.*
5. **Light Shift** — Beacons change midapproach; your lane just moved. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *Someone paid the Lantern Clerk. Find out who or drift into the reefs.*
6. **Pilot Strike** — No escorts available; average unpaid, risk assumed. ‘[LABOR]’ *The pilots sit in their guildhall, drinking tea, watching ships founder.*
7. **Customs Inspection** — Ladder audits cargo and crew; delays bite deep. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The inspector has a silver tooth. He smiles when he sees a manifest.*

8. **Reef-Runners** — Corsair skiffs circle with boarding hooks; steel in the spray. '[COMBAT]' *Their leader wears a MirrorKeeper's badge stolen or earned, you cannot tell.*
9. **Jurisdiction Flip** — Lanternlaw shifts; your writ no longer bites. '[JUSTICE]' *The tide turned. So did the magistrate. Your safeconduct is now kindling.*
10. **Fire Risk** — Alchemical cargo aboard; quarantine if anything spills. '[DISASTER]' *A single spark and the whole quay becomes a crater. The factor wants you to know this.*
- J **Quartermaster Betrayal** — Tidetables sold to rival; route compromised. '[SOCIAL]' *The betrayal is written in lemon juice; heat reveals the name.*
- Q **Yellow Flag** — Port quarantine; deadlines rot on the hook. '[DEATH]' *The flag is dyed with turmeric and something else something that smells sweet.*
- K **Fleet Redeploy** — "Safe" corridor becomes parade ground; chaos in formation. '[AUTHORITY]' *Admirals play chess with real ships, and you are a pawn.*
- A **Black Squall (at the Pointe)** — Scatters ships and stories alike. '[WEATHER]' '[DEATH]' *This is no natural storm. The water hisses. Something below is waking.*
- + **Web Unravelled** — A Lethaiar agent is exposed. The oligarchs turn on each other, accusing every rival of being a spider. '[POLITICS]' '[FEAR]' *Silk threads appear on every doorknob. No one trusts their shadow.*

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

(Unchanged; the existing rewards work well for a thalassocracy.)

2. **Mooring Chit** — Skip the Mooring Roll once; harbour favours you. '[TRAVEL]' *The chit is a dried seahorse shell. Keep it away from salt.*
3. **Pilotage Token** — One certified escort through a bad channel. '[TRAVEL]' *The pilot who accepts it must touch your shoulder before speaking.*
4. **Fee Waiver** — Cargo cleared today; ledger smiles included. '[TRADE]' *The clerk stamps it twice once for the crown, once for the Hollow.*
5. **Safe-Conduct** — Along specific beacons lane; law walks with you. '[TRAVEL]' *The commodore's seal is warm. It cools as the exit nears.*
6. **Salvage Rights** — On named quay or reach; flotsam becomes fortune. '[TRADE]' *You must name each piece before touching it. The wrong word forfeits the claim.*
7. **Warehouse Access** — Bonded storage; seal prize before rivals sniff. '[TRADE]' *The key is a bronze finger. It fits only one lock and breaks after use.*
8. **Lantern Code** — Tonight's signals revealed; navigation advantage. '[TRAVEL]' *Three quick flashes: safe passage. One long, two short: the Admiralty is watching.*
9. **Dredging Grant** — You decide where next channel runs; reshape the sea. '[AUTHORITY]' *The dredgers are convicts. They work faster if you promise a name in their favour.*
10. **Letter of Marque** — Convoy protection for one season; legal blades. '[COMBAT]' *The ink is mixed with gunpowder. It smokes slightly when read.*
- J **Admiralty Judgment** — Precedent travels with you; law bends. '[JUSTICE]' *The case number is burned into a leather tag. Tag it to a belt loop.*
- Q **Mirror Warrant** — Legal right to post a beacon; redraw the map. '[AUTHORITY]' *The MirrorKeeper's seal, still warm. The channel you mark becomes law until challenged.*
- K **Spice Share** — Stake in Kassamira auction floor; profit in pepper. '[TRADE]' *The share is*

a peppercorn sealed in wax. Bite it to test authenticity.

A **Lantern License** — Temporary authority to redefine the lane. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The harbour master spits when he hands it over. Use it wisely or not at all.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (25 → 4, 610 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (papers/rights/priority) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **sea & signal** motifs beacons that migrate, tides that remember, law that flows like water. If a King or Ace of Spades appears, also echo **web motifs** silk threads on a bollard, a reflection that holds too long, the faint smell of spiced tea (the Lethaiar are near).

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Pilot’s Mirror:** Kahfagia’s strength is not its fleet but its monopoly on light and lane. To post a beacon is to redraw the map. Any character with a Mirror Warrant may permanently move a beacon or buoy (GM sets a 4segment clock). For the duration of that clock, all navigation rolls on that lane are at +1 Position for the party and 1 Position for rivals.
- **Lantern-Law Privilege:** While flying an Admiralty flag or carrying a valid Lantern License, your ship may pass through chainbooms and customs points at +1 Position. The first time in a session you invoke this privilege, the GM gains 1 SB (the Admiralty is watching).
- **Oligarchic Favour (Leverage Track):** Instead of tracking coin debts, track *Favour* with the great families (alKassam, Carrasco, Mirat, etc.). Favour 13 gives you access to private docks, early auction warnings, and offthebooks pilots. Favour 4+ lets you call in a family to block a rival’s safeconduct or raise a false alarm on their ship.
- **The Web’s Patience (Secret Clock [6]):** Tracks the Lethaiar infiltration of the Shadow Council. The clock ticks when the party helps a Lethaiar agent, exposes a rival house’s secrets, or ignores a silken thread. At 3, the Harpist’s name appears on a dockmaster’s manifest. At 6, the Empty Chair is filled and the new house head bows to a greyrobed stranger. The party may reduce the clock by exposing an agent or by warning an oligarch (costs Favour 2).
- **Western Reach Rumours:** Once per port visit, a character may roll Wits + Lore (DV 3) to hear a rumour from a captain returned from beyond the mirror. On success, the GM reveals one of the six rumours (see below) as a foreshadowing hook or a clue for an ongoing arc.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Lantern Bearer** The Traveler. *A light that never goes out; a promise that never sinks.*
 - **The Mirror-King** The Witness. *Reflections that remember every lie, every promise, every cargo.*
 - **The Tide Father** Khemesh. *The pressure beneath the keel; the debt that the sea collects at ebb.*
 - **The Spider’s Daughter** Inaea (secret). *The web that binds the oligarchs, strand by patient strand.*
 - **The Unlit** Ikasha. *The ninth lamp that is never lit; the safe harbour that exists only

in rumour.*

Lore Echoes (CrossExpansion Hooks)

- **Saint Alvaro of the Lantern (The Traveler):** The Admiralty’s mirrortowers double as wayshrines for the Saint of Lost Channels. Sailors who light a candle before a voyage and whisper a destination to the mirror claim the tide will not turn against them before they reach it. The MirrorKeepers charge a fee for this service payable in salt, not silver.
- **The Silken Coup (Inaea):** The Lethaiar call their infiltration the *Genteel Harvest*. They do not conquer; they adopt. An oligarch who accepts a greyrobed advisor finds that their children are betrothed to shadowkin, their ledgers are copied in disappearing ink, and their mirrortower shows only the face they wish to see not the one that watches them sleep.
- **The TideSworn Compact (The Admiral of Sealed Tides):** A small but influential order of notaries based in Kassamira Port. They adjudicate disputes over beacon rights, cargo claims, and pilotage fees. Their judgments are always delivered in triplicate, and they accept no bribes only binding oaths. Those who lie before a Covenant judge find that their next three voyages are plagued by contrary winds.
- **The Hospitallers of the Salted Veil (The Bitter Root):** A hospice on Deadman’s Quay is run by greyrobed healers of the Order. They ask no payment, but they never forget a face. It is said that if you accept their care, you owe a favour to the sea itself and the sea always collects. Smugglers leave small offerings of fresh water on the pier to stay in the Order’s good graces.
- **The Ninth:** In any lanternlit scene, the ninth lamp lit in a room reveals a threshold. The wise stop at eight. Those who light the ninth are said to see a figure standing on the water outside the window waiting.

Kahfagia Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Wake:** Toss a crust over your shoulder before entering a new channel. Ignore the first *Smothering Fog* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Turn the Lantern:** Spin the binnacle lamp once counterclockwise. Cancel *Boom Slam* or take 1 die on your next pilot check (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Deep:** Whisper a true name into a lead line. Gain +1 Effect against corsairs for the scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Tide Court. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Cut the Thread:** If you find a silk thread on your bollard, cut it with a silver knife. Negate the next *Web’s Patience* tick. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

(Unchanged; see earlier table.)

Western Reach Rumours (d6, fast hooks)

1. A harbour where bells toll under water; cargo *must* be named aloud.
2. A spice that stops bleeding until moonrise.
3. A mirrorreef that reflects storms from a week ahead.
4. A pilotage guild that uses birds, not beacons.

5. A fleet that sails by *shadow* cast on fog.
6. A court that weighs debts in *breath*, not coin.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Sail + Wits):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Wake Surge*.
- **Cut the Lane (Pilot + Tactics):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a beacon is under your colour, +1 die.
- **Weather the Squall (Resolve + Sail):** On a hit in *Black Squall*, you pick who drifts; on a miss, the Keeper does.

Boss Seeds (Sea & Signal / Web & Silk)

- **The Mirror-Keeper of Kassamira (signal tyrant)** *Phases:* Audit → Blacklist → Light Embargo. *Cracks:* rival beacon logs, Tide Court precedent, stolen codebook.
- **Corsair-Chaplain of the Pointe (relic raider)** *Phases:* Charm → Board → Bell-Wake. *Cracks:* sanctified boom, cofradía oath, drowned saint tithe.
- **The Veiled Harpist (Spider’s Daughter)** *Phases:* Whisper → Weave → Harvest. *Cracks:* speak a true name of a Lethaiar agent, cut a strand of the Web with silver, or remind an oligarch of a debt older than the Spider’s memory.

Patronage & Power

In Kahfagia, power flows through control of the sea lanes themselves and through the silken threads that bind the oligarchs to the Spider’s will. The maritime oligarchs have built their empire not through conquest of territory but through mastery of navigation and the quiet manipulation of debt. Every beacon, every channel marker, every mirrorlight is both a navigational aid and a legal instrument. But behind every mirror, a greyrobed woman watches. And she is very, very patient.

For the GM: Kahfagian patronage revolves around access to channels, to cargo, to legal protection. Rewards often take the form of pilotage tokens, safeconducts, or salvage rights. But the secret war of the Lethaiar adds a new layer: players may be hired to expose an agent, to protect an oligarch from being “woven,” or even to ally with the Spider’s children for a share of the Harvest. Use the **Web’s Patience** clock to track the infiltration; let players decide whether to slow it, accelerate it, or ride it to power.

Amaria The Iron Shore

A small peninsula squeezed between Kahfagia’s Akilan holdings and the Oshiiran border, Amaria is a land of iron mines, coastal fog, and hybrid law. Ecktoria once claimed it; now it pays tribute to both Kahfagia and Oshiira to stay independent. Its people speak a creole of Kahfagian maritime slang and Oshiiran bureaucratic precision, and its courts rule by a blend of Admiralty tariff law and Vermilion Corps ledgerjustice.

What you notice first: The smell of rust and brine. The way every official carries two seals one for Kahfagia, one for Oshiira. The constant ticking of waterclocks that never agree on the hour.

The rule that kills newcomers: Never carry only one flag. Amarian vessels fly both the lantern and the grain sheaf. A single flag is a declaration of allegiance and an invitation to be sunk by the other side.

Quick Generators for Amaria (d6 each)

Spades Places (d6)

1. **Iron Quay** A pier built from salvaged warship timbers. The nails are iron from the inland mines; they rust red, staining the water like blood. '[INDUSTRY]'
2. **CoinHouse of Two Ledgers** A countinghouse where every transaction is recorded twice once for the Kahfagian tariff, once for the Oshiiran grain tithe. The third ledger is the smuggler's. '[TRADE]'
3. **Fog Lighthouse (Disputed)** A stone tower with two lamps: one green for Kahfagia, one white for Oshiira. Only one is lit at a time. The keeper changes them with the tide. '[AUTHORITY]'
4. **Smuggler's Rope-Walk** A hidden cove where boats land at low tide. The ropewalk is a series of knotted lines that lead to a cave full of untaxed cargo. '[STEALTH]'
5. **Mine Shaft of the Ninth Vein** An iron mine that goes deeper than the surveyors mapped. The miners whisper of a sealed door at the bottom Aeler work, they say. '[MYSTERY]'
6. **Dual Customs Post** A wooden shack with two windows: one for Kahfagian stamps, one for Oshiiran seals. The line snakes between them. Smugglers pay both clerks and skip the line. '[AUTHORITY]'

Hearts People (d6)

1. **TwoLedger Clerk** Sits at a split desk, writing with two hands. Her left hand files Kahfagian tariffs; her right, Oshiiran grain receipts. Her third hand the one no one sees writes the real numbers. '[TRADE]'
2. **Iron Miner (Free)** A former indentured labourer who bought his freedom with a year's ore. His hands are stained red with rust. He knows the sealed door's location but will not speak of it. '[LABOR]'
3. **Smuggler Captain** Flies no flag. His ship's name changes with each port. He speaks four languages badly and navigates by the taste of salt on the wind. '[STEALTH]'
4. **Kahfagian Customs Agent** A oneeyed woman with a brass hook for a hand. She stamps cargo with a bellshaped seal. The seal rings when the declared value is a lie. '[AUTHORITY]'
5. **Oshiiran Grain Auditor** Thin, spectacled, carries a grain balance. He measures every sack against the Widow's standard. He has found nine thieves this year. The tenth was his own clerk. '[JUSTICE]'
6. **Fog Keeper (Lighthouse)** An old sailor who lost his sight to a Kahfagian mirror flash. He tends the lamps by touch. He knows which flag flies by the heat of the glass green is cool, white is warm. '[WEATHER]'

Clubs Complications (d6)

1. **Tariff DoubleCross** Both Kahfagia and Oshiira claim the same customs fee. Pay one, and the other impounds your cargo. Pay both, and you are bankrupt. Smuggle, and you are a patriot. '[DEBT]'

2. **Mine Collapse (Sealed Door)** A cavein opens a passage to the sealed Aeler door. The miners are afraid. Something is breathing on the other side. The party is asked to investigate or to seal it again. ‘[DISASTER]’
3. **Lighthouse Outage** Both lamps go dark. Ships founder on the reef. The keeper is found dead, one hand on each lamp. The cause of death: old age or old debt. ‘[DEATH]’
4. **Census Dispute** Oshiira claims Amaria’s population for grain tithes; Kahfagia claims it for port taxes. The same people are counted twice or not at all. The party is asked to audit the ledgers. The ledgers are on fire. ‘[POLITICS]’
5. **Iron Embargo** A rival faction sinks an ore barge. Both powers blame each other. The price of iron spikes. The party’s cargo is now worth a fortune and a target. ‘[COMBAT]’
6. **The Ninth Vein Opens** The sealed door cracks. A cold wind blows from the deep. The miners flee. A voice whispers a name the name of the party member who owes the deepest debt. ‘[MYSTERY]’

Diamonds Rewards (d6)

1. **Dual Customs Stamp** One stamp, two seals. Passes both Kahfagian and Oshiiran checkpoints without inspection. Use once per journey. ‘[TRAVEL]’
2. **Iron Ingot (Ninth Vein)** A bar of ore from the sealed door’s chamber. It is warm to the touch. Aeler runes glow on its surface. Trade it to the True Masons for a favour. ‘[TRADE]’
3. **Fog Keeper’s Log** A journal of tide and lamp schedules. Decode it to predict when the disputed lighthouse will be unguarded. Gain +1 Position on smuggling attempts. ‘[WEATHER]’
4. **TwoLedger Receipt** A document that proves you paid both tariffs. It is written in disappearing ink. The ink vanishes after one use but the paper remembers. ‘[JUSTICE]’
5. **Miner’s Compass** A brass needle that points to the sealed door. It also points to the nearest iron vein and to the nearest heart that beats with greed. ‘[TRAVEL]’
6. **Smuggler’s Flag (Neutral)** A plain grey banner. Fly it to pass between Kahfagian and Oshiiran patrols unmolested. The patrols will not salute. They will not shoot. They will pretend they did not see you. ‘[STEALTH]’

Chapter 2

Ecktoria

Marble & Fire.

My grandfather was a senator. He voted to burn the Ykrul tribute-pact, and then he voted to burn the inquiry into why the grain ships sank. He signed his name in wax and watched the city burn three times. He never raised his voice.

I am a Coin-House Factor. I seal deals with three ribbonswhite for "ask," red for "now," black for "never." I have never used the black ribbon. Not because I am kind, but because "never" is a debt I cannot collect.

Ecktoria is an Empire that never quite diedmore like a corpse propped up by gilded scaffolding and the stubborn refusal of its undertakers to admit the job's done. The Everflame burns in every basilica not as a symbol of divine truth, but as a literal lie detector: swear a false oath near it, and your tongue turns black. I have seen a merchant's tongue turn black mid-sentence. He finished his lie anyway. The buyers pretended not to notice. *That is Ecktoria.*

The statues watch. The fire judges. The marble remembers every name carved into its stepsand every name left out.

Do not refuse a toast in a coin-house. The ledgers are the true judges, and a declined cup is a declined credit. You will not borrow again.

Marcus of the Red Ledger, Coin-House Factor, third generation

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Spiced flatbread dipped in olive oil and honeybut only if you can afford the honey. The poor eat millet porridge with a single dried fig. The fig is counted as part of the household's grain allowance.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count coins by touch. Every

Ecktorian child has a box of worn sesterces; by age five, they can tell a debased copper from pure silver by the weight alone.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their signature. Ecktorians judge by handwriting before face. A clerk with a steady hand is trustworthy. A noble with a flourish is hiding something. A merchant who signs with an X is not worth doing business with.

What is the most common crime? Tax evasion but it is not a crime, it is a sport. Every household keeps two ledgers: the white one for the Censor, the red one for the family. The art is in keeping the red ledger from looking like a confession.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Censor's clerks are paid to find discrepancies. They are also paid to lose them. The price of a lost discrepancy is exactly 5% of the tax owed. This is not corruption. It is "administrative flexibility."

Where do people go when they die? The family crypt, beneath the basilica floor. The wealthy are burned, their ashes mixed with marble dust and pressed into the floor tiles. The poor are buried in unmarked graves outside the walls. The Everflame's light does not reach that far.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You petition the Censor to have the wrong stricken from the public record. The petition costs a tenth of your annual income. If accepted, the wrong is erased legally, it never happened. If rejected, the wrong is published, and you lose your civic standing.

What is the most important festival? The Triumph of the Flame (autumn equinox). The basilica's central flame is carried in procession through every district. To touch the flame is to be absolved of petty debts. To be burned by it is a sign that your debts are not petty.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Grand Magistrate's seal is a forgery. The original cracked in 783 AR. The current seal was carved by a prison engraver who was executed to keep the secret. The engraver's apprentice is still alive. They live in Silkstrand. They have the original sketches.

2.1 Ecktoria — “Marble & Fire”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The flame remembers. The marble cracks. The law forgets but the statues watch.*

Grand Magistrate (Elite): “The law is written in marble and witnessed by the flame. Every judgment echoes in the stones but the stones have grown quiet. The patricians do not listen. They have forgotten what the flame tastes like. They seal their windows with silk and call it governance.”

Ferrymaster (Commoner): “I’ve seen the city burn three times. The marble remembers the heat. The flame remembers the lies. The rich have stopped looking at the flames. They only look at each other and at the cracks in their own mirrors. The fire isn’t burning anymore, friend. It’s *smiling*.”

Genre / Mood: Imperial decay, bureaucratic horror, memory as weight, Renaissance decadence a city walled off from its own rot, where the wealthy dance while the poor cough ash.

Starting Location: The Coin-House floor, marble cracked with soot lines, where votive candles gutter beside melted icons. A factor with smoke-stained fingers offers a folded note. “The Lame King moves tonight. The Basilica burns with him. The Amber Palace hasn’t answered a summons in a month. Find out who lit the fire or the Vigil will audit your soul at dawn. And stay away from the Arena. The statues have been *whispering*.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Once the heart of the Utaran Empire, Ecktoria has worn its laurels into chains. Three centuries of sack, fire, and slow decline have not stripped its marble forums nor its gold-sealed coin-houses but each day, more of its weight slips into the hands of mercenaries and whispers. The Black Banners march on its purse, avenging old Ykrul wounds by proxy. Processions still crown its stairways, yet ash lines every step. The city burns not only with memory, but with a grief that refuses to name itself.

Yet the true sickness is not in the streets. It is in the **Amber Palace**, where the old patrician families have walled themselves away. They sit on laurels preserved from the empire, drinking wine that costs a village’s harvest, whispering deals with merchants who have never seen a loom. **Maelstraeus**, the demon of commerce, has threaded their ledgers with invisible interest; every contract they sign forgets a clause. **Livaea**, the demon of desire, has wrapped their hearts in silk; they marry for influence, divorce for scandal, and love only the reflection of themselves in gilded mirrors reflections that no longer blink. The common folk call them the *Unburdened* not because they carry no weight, but because they have forgotten what weight *feels* like.

The **Vigil** once the empire’s secret police, now a fractured ghost of an institution fights a silent war over the dream of restoration. One faction, the **Censer-Knights**, serves the Everflame and the Synod, hunting heresy and latent magic with brass censers and bells that ring at dawn. Another, the **Unburnt**, answers only to the old patrician houses, ensuring that no whisper of rebellion reaches the Amber Palace. A third, the **Red Vigil**, has sold itself to Maelstraeus, auditing not coin but *memory* they collect the names of those who have forgotten what they owe. They do not fight each other openly. They meet in the hypogeum of the Arena, under the gaze of statues that weep marble tears. The statues are not decorative.

They are the city's *witnesses*.

Beyond the capital's walls, the province is a patchwork of struggling towns, abandoned fortresses, and grainlands whose harvests are disputed by rival tax-collectors. The Everflame Orthodoxy preaches unity, but each sermon is a coded signal for a political camp. The statues watch. The fire judges. And in the sewers, the Vigil's informers listen for the name of the next person to vanish not into death, but into the margins of a ledger no one will ever read.

What you notice first: The smell of old incense and fresh bread and beneath it, the faint sweetness of rot. The way crowds part for a procession and close again for a knife. The marble steps, worn smooth by centuries of petitioners. The way the wealthy never step on the cracks. The cracks are where the petitions of the poor are wedged. The cracks are where the Hollow reads.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never refuse a toast in a coin-house. The ledgers are the true judges, and a declined cup is a declined credit. You will not borrow again. But more than that: never accept a gift from a patrician without naming its price aloud. Maelstraeus and Livaea both listen, and a gift accepted in silence is a contract written in water it will drown you eventually.

Regional Mood: The Flame That Remembers And The Dancers Who Forgot

Here, the past does not fade it is polished into monuments. Every statue, every obelisk, every triumphal arch is a legal precedent carved in stone. But precedent is not justice. Precedent is *memory*, and memory is a weight that the city carries like a cracked keel. Ecktoria is not one city but three: the marble forums of the old patricians (where the Unburdened hold masques that last for weeks, their faces painted with ash from the Everflame), the soot-stained alleys of the mercenary camps (where Black Banner captains drink with Vigil informers), and the basilicas where the Everflame's priests balance piety against profit (and sometimes sell indulgences for the sin of being born poor). The Grand Magistrate presides over a skeleton empire, but the real power moves in coin-houses, grain ledgers, and the whispered judgments of the Censor's Hall and in the *dreams* of patricians who no longer remember the scent of rain.

The **Vigil** does not patrol the streets. It *permeates* them. Every tavern has an informer; every bathhouse has a spy; every marriage is witnessed by someone who reports to a faction of the Vigil. The **Censer-Knights** hunt unlicensed magic; the **Unburnt** hunt sedition; the **Red Vigil** hunts *what was forgotten*. They are not allies. They are not enemies. They are three creditors fighting over the same soul and the soul is the city's.

The **patricians** the Old Blood no longer govern. They *perform* governance. A session of the Parlement might see two senators debate the price of grain while their slaves hold silver trays of honeyed figs. A decree might be passed that doubles the salt tax, then rescinded an hour later because a duchess sneezed. They are not cruel. They are *distracted*. Livaea has taught them to crave the next pleasure before they have finished the current one. Maelstraeus has taught them that every transaction is a game, and every game is winnable if you have enough coin but they have forgotten that the house always wins. The house is the Hollow.

The **Everflame** still burns in the basilicas, but its light has grown dim. The High Priest speaks of unity, but his sermons are interrupted by coughing from the pews not from illness, but from the ash that falls like snow. The common folk whisper that the flame no longer judges truth; it only *records* it, filing confessions in a vault that no one ever opens. The Vigil has a key. The patricians have a copy. The poor have nothing but their names, which the Censor's Hall writes in ink that

fades when you look away.

The Everflame Faith of Ash and Incense

The state religion of Ecktoria is a syncretic faith that venerates the Eternal Flame as the divine principle, but its power flows through three great Orders, each devoted to a different Patron. The Basilica of the Unquenched Flame is the heart of the city: a cavernous space of gold mosaics, weeping saints, and the perpetual smell of beeswax and myrrh. Mass is held at dawn and dusk, the congregation coughing through the ash that falls from the censers. The priests sell indulgences in the side chapels—a silver coin for the remission of a small sin, a gold coin for a large one, a horse for a murder. The choir sings in Utaran, a language most parishioners no longer understand, but the melody is beautiful enough to make them weep and to make the statues turn their heads.

- **Order of the Oath of Flame & Light (Orthodox)** The public face of the church. They lead processions, bless marriages, and anoint the dying. Their rites are those of vows, radiance, and protection. They are the ones who light the great candles at dawn. Many are sincere; most are tired. The tired ones are the ones the Vigil watches.
- **Order of the Inquisitor Prime (Prosecutorial)** The **Censer-Knights**. They hunt untutored magic, root out demonic cults, and enforce the purity of the flame. Their rites are those of judgment, purification, and burning censure. They carry brass censers that smoke with bitter herbs, and bells that ring once for a warning, thrice for a raid. They are feared, but also respected—for they are the only ones who still take the flame *seriously*. And the flame takes them seriously in return.
- **Order of the Oath of Mercy and Grace (Hospitalier)** The healers and confessors. They run hospices, tend to the sick, and hear the confessions of the dying. Their rites are those of healing, forgiveness, and the spiral of care. They are often at odds with the Inquisitor Prime—mercy can look like leniency. The common folk love them; the patricians ignore them. The Vigil watches both.

The Everflame is both beautiful and ugly. Its gold leaf covers the same marble where debtors once scratched their names. Its hymns are sung by choirboys whose families sold them for a loaf of bread. Its relics—a nail from the True Cross, a tear of Saint Lucia—draw pilgrims from across the empire, but the priests charge admission, and the poor sleep on the steps. The flame itself is a wonder: a pillar of blue-white fire that never gutters, tended by the High Priest alone. It is said to show the truth to any who stare into it long enough—and to show the same truth to the Vigil, who watch from the shadows. The truth is always the same: *you have forgotten something*.

At a Glance

- **Atmosphere:** Marble grandeur, ash-tipped ambition, the slow rot of imperial forms, and the cloying sweetness of a city drowning in its own nostalgia.
- **Key Conflict:** Legitimacy versus wealth; old families, new mercenaries, and the Everflame’s judgment—but beneath it all, the battle between Maelstræus (greed) and Livaea (desire) over the souls of the powerful.
- **Notable Threats:** Bread riots, arena spills, ducal conflicts, inquisitorial visits, the Red List and the Vigil’s three factions, who may arrest you for debt, sedition, or simply being *remembered*.
- **Common Rewards:** Procession permits, coin-house credit, laurel deeds, a Golden Edict carved in precedent—and, if you are brave, a secret from the Vigil’s own ledgers. The secret is always about a statue.

Prominent NPCs of Ecktoria

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Valerius	Grand Magistrate	Preserve the forms of law while the empire crumbles	His gavel is a sundial; it only strikes at noon. He has not struck it in a year.
Flavia	High Priest of the Ever-flame	Balance the factions and keep the flame lit	She has never raised her voice; the flame speaks for her. Lately, it speaks in the voices of the dead.
Cassia	Duchess-Regent of the Dolmis Gate	Protect her family's trading rights	She rules from behind a silk screen; a dagger-hole is cut at eye level. The screen was a gift from Livaea. The silk is warm.
Marcus	Coin-House Factor	Survive the next credit panic	He seals deals with three ribbons: white (ask), red (now), black (never). His black ribbon is fraying. He does not know who is fraying it.

Lucius	Lanista (arena master)	Own the next champion and the secrets of the hypogeum	His fighters’ brands are his signature; he never repeats a mark. One brand is a spiral the mark of the Red Vigil. The fighter does not know.
The Red Clerk	Censor’s Hall scribe	Control which names are remembered	His inkwell is a skull; the skull belonged to a name he erased. He has forgotten his own name. The skull remembers.
Censer-Knight Commander Vorenius	Prefect of the Order of the Inquisitor Prime	Hunt untutored magic before it wakes the Ninth	His lantern burns green. He says it shows the truth. His shadow has two heads one for each faction he has betrayed. He does not notice the third.
Lady Aelia	Patrician heiress, Livaea’s favourite	Outshine every rival before the next masque	She has not left the Amber Palace in seven years. She does not know the price of bread. She dreams of bread.

Names of Ecktoria

Inspired by late Latin and early Romance: strong vowels (ae, i, o), soft endings, and the weight of imperial bureaucracy. Surnames often denote a place of origin, a trade, or a notable ancestor.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Valerius	Flavia	de Urbe	<i>the Iron</i>
Marcus	Cassia	Aquilinus	<i>the Coin-Wise</i>
Lucius	Aelia	Honoratus	<i>Flame-Touched</i>
Tiberius	Cornelia	Lateranus	<i>the Unburned</i>
Gaius	Livia	Silvanus	<i>Bread-Counter</i>
Decimus	Valeria	Portinari	<i>Ash-Finger</i>

The Three Ecktorias: Faction Spectrum

Ecktoria is not a single polity but a battlefield of three competing visions. Most citizens and factions fall somewhere between these poles, shifting allegiance as the grain price changes. Superimposed on them are the whispers of Maelstraeus and Livaea, who have no faction — only debtors.

- **Old Blood (Patrician Traditionalists)** – The ancient senatorial families who remember when Ecktoria ruled the world. They worship precedent, hoard marble, and see mercenaries as necessary filth. Their power is in law, lineage, and the silent networks of the Censor’s Hall. *Clocks: PATRICIAN PATIENCE [4], BLOOD DEBT [6]. Patron whispers:* Livaea — they marry for influence, betray for pleasure, and mistake cruelty for wit. They mistake silence for consent.
- **Black Purse (Mercenary & Trade Leagues)** – The new power: condotta brokers, coin-house factors, and mercenary captains who have bought what birth could not give. They care about supply lines, not bloodlines. Their loyalty is to the next contract, and their god is the ledger — but the ledger has no god. *Clocks: CONTRACT SPIRAL [4], PAYDAY FEVER [6]. Patron whispers:* Maelstraeus — they measure profit in interest, interest in suffering, and suffering in silver. They do not measure the weight of marble.
- **The Everflame (Church & Inquisition)** – The priests, inquisitors, and relic-keepers who claim that the Eternal Flame is the only true sovereign. They offer legitimacy to whoever pays the tithe — and withdraw it from whoever forgets. Their power is in pulpits, processions, and the fear of excommunication. *Clocks: HERESY INDEX [4], SANCTUARY VIOLATION [6]. Patron whispers:* Neither — the Everflame remembers, but the Vigil has learned to filter its truths. The flame’s truth is ash; the Vigil’s truth is silence.

Superimposed on these are the **Ykrul creditors** (who hold Ecktoria’s debt like a leash), the **Black Banners** (who hold its streets like a lease), and the **Vigil** (who hold its secrets like a knife and sometimes use it). A wise politician learns to balance all three — and keeps a boat ready on the Dolmis.

The Vigil — Three Faces of the Secret Police

The Vigil is not one order but three, each claiming the mantle of the old imperial secret police. They do not cooperate. They do not war. They *audit* each other. They also audit the dead.

- **The Censer-Knights (Orthodox, Everflame)** — Hunters of untutored magic. They carry brass censers that smoke with bitter herbs and bells that ring once for a warning, thrice for a raid. They answer to the Synod and the High Priest, but their true loyalty is to the *precedent* — the law that magic must be licensed, indexed, and taxed. A Censer-Knight raid is heralded by a single, low bell. They are the most feared and the most public. They are also the most forgetful. *Clocks: CANDLE-SMOKE SWEEP [4], HERETIC INDEX [6].*

- **The Unburnt (Patrician)** Bodyguards and spies of the Amber Palace. They wear red sashes and carry no visible weapons. Their job is to ensure that no whisper of rebellion, no bread riot, no debt revolt ever reaches a patrician’s ear. They are experts at *redaction* not killing witnesses, but making them forget. They have forgotten their own names. *Clocks: PALACE SECRETS* [4], *REDACTED MEMORY* [6].
- **The Red Vigil (Maelstraeus’s Own)** Debt-collectors and interest-enforcers. They serve no noble, no church, no magistrate only the ledger. They audit the wealthy for the wealthy, finding hidden obligations, unpaid tithes, and compound interest that has grown teeth. A Red Vigil agent never demands coin. They demand *names*. They also demand silence the silence of the forgotten. *Clocks: INTEREST DUE* [4], *LEDGER OF NAMES* [6].

The Vigil’s three commanders meet once a month in the hypogeum of the Arena, under the gaze of statues that weep marble tears. No record is kept of these meetings. No one admits they happen. The common folk say that if you see a Vigil agent, it is already too late but they cannot agree on *which* Vigil. The statues know. The statues do not tell.

Spades Places (revised tone)

2. **Petition Steps** — Milk-stone worn smooth by a thousand hopeful knees. The petitions are written in ink and wax. The steps answer in silence, and the silence is a verdict: Your claim is under review. A clerk sweeps the steps at dawn. He never reads the petitions. He weighs them. The heaviest goes to the bottom of the pile. The pile is the city’s memory.
3. **Tally-Ford Ferryhouse** — Rope-drums thrum all day; the ferrymaster watches coin and banners. The rope-drums have a pattern. It spells the names of those who paid late and the names of those who forgot they owed. The ferrymaster has a brother in the Red Vigil. They do not speak.
4. **Everflame Cloister** — Candle markets and side-chapels. The flame has a voice. It is the voice of the last liar who tested it. Lately, it speaks in a whisper. The whisper is always the same: “*I remember. I remember. I remember.*” Those who listen too long forget their own names and start reciting the names of the city’s forgotten dead.
5. **Triumph Stairs** — Marble worn smooth by ambition. The stairs have a name: The Rise of the Forgotten. No one remembers why. The patricians still climb them at noon, their retainers counting the steps aloud. They never count to nine. The ninth step is a gap. The gap is where a senator fell or was pushed or simply forgot to step. His ghost is still climbing. He has been climbing for a century.
6. **Censor’s Hall** — Red-lacquered tablets record every name, every shame. The tablets are redacted in invisible ink. The truth is underneath. The Vigil has the reagent. The reagent is made from the tears of the last censor who told the truth. He is still crying.

Hearts People & Factions (revised tone)

2. **Torchbearer Child** — Ash-smudged hands, knowing every shortcut through the ruins. The ruins are not old. They are last year’s fashionable quarter, abandoned when the mortgage was reclassified. She has never been lost. The ruins speak to her in the language of eviction notices. She reads them aloud to the rats. The rats pay her in stolen bread.
3. **Decumanus-Master** — Surveyor who moves stones. His rod is a finger bone. The bone belonged to the last surveyor who argued. He does not rewrite the map. He rewrites the *memory* of the map. This street was always a cul-de-sac. You simply forgot. The Vigil pays

him in forgotten names.

4. **Censer-Knight Commander Voreus** — His lantern burns green. He says it shows the truth. His shadow has two heads — one for each faction he has betrayed. He does not see the third head. The third head is his own, from a timeline where he kept his oath. It is weeping.

Clubs Complications/Threats (revised tone)

2. **Blocked Bridge** — A funeral procession for a pauper who died in debt. The law says the corpse cannot cross until the toll is paid. The family has no coin. The law does not accept stories. The corpse is beginning to smell, and the Hollow is beginning to notice a debt that cannot be buried. The Vigil is taking notes on who stops to help.
3. **Border Dispute** — A surveyor has moved a boundary stone three feet east. The new map shows your warehouse now stands on a public thoroughfare. The old map is in the archive. The archive wing collapsed last spring. The memory of the boundary now exists only in the cracked floor of the basilica, and the basilica is accepting sealed bids for reparative memory. The Vigil has already bid.

Diamonds Rewards/Leverage (revised tone)

2. **Procession Permit** — Move sacred flame through a crowded quarter; law walks with you. The permit is a torch. Carry it, and the city will part — or burn. The Vigil will follow. The flame will flicker when you lie. The permit is signed by a clerk who died three years ago. His ghost still signs.
3. **Golden Edict** — An exception carved in marble; precedent travels like law. The edict is a crack. The crack in the law is now an opening. The Vigil is already inside. They will leave a note. The note will say: *“We remember. Do you?”*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (papers/favor/precedence) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **marble and fire** motifs — statues that turn their heads, flames that burn blue, law that remembers every name — and also echo the **Vigil’s presence**: a cough in the crowd, a seal on a document you did not stamp, a mirror that shows a different face. The different face is always older. It is always watching.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Imperial Ruins**: Every district bears halfcollapsed arcades, serving as markets, courts, or shelters for mercenary companies. The Vigil knows every hidden passage.
- **Competing Factions**: Dukes, guilds, and priests stage processions that collide at bridges and squares, each claiming legitimacy. The Vigil collects bets on the outcome.
- **Monuments as Weapons**: Statues, obelisks, and colonnades are not only symbols — they are barricades, rallying points, and high ground when the city riots. The Vigil has a map of which statues can be toppled.

- **Everflame Orthodoxy:** The basilicas preach unity, but each sermon is a coded signal for a political camp. The High Priest plays balance while cultivating his own following. The Vigil decodes every sermon.
- **Black Banner Contracts:** Foreign mercenaries fill the gaps left by a shrinking citizen levy, their loyalty secured only by steady coin. The Vigil audits their pay.
- **The Amber Palace Quarantine:** The patricians have not left the palace in a decade. No one is certain if they are prisoners or patrons. The Vigil maintains the perimeter and delivers the wine.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Saints & Cults):**
 - **St. Marcellus of the Gilded Scale (Mykkiel)** *The Justiciar*. His order enforces unwritten laws; reading a sealed precedent binds the reader to enforce it. His shrine is the Censor’s Hall. The Vigil keeps a copy of every precedent.
 - **St. Valeria of the Serpent (Isoka)** *The Shedding Saint*. Pilgrims who confess at her chapel forget one sin and one kindness. Her mosaic shows a snake eating its tail. The Vigil uses her chapel to erase memories.
 - **St. Lucia of the Undying Flame (Oath of Flame & Light)** *The Witness of Embers*. Any oath sworn over her shrine’s flame cannot be broken; the breaker sees their own face in every wave until they drown. The Vigil swears oaths there and never breaks them.
 - **The Reckoner (Maelstraeus)** *The Ledger Keeper*. A mystery cult of coinhouse factors. They offer credit at the cost of a hidden interest that compounds in blood. The Red Vigil are their debtcollectors.
 - **The Ember Prefect (Heretic Cult)** A schism that believes the flame should not be contained. They meet in the arena hypogeum, chanting the *Unspoken Ninth Citation*. The Grand Magistrate has outlawed them three times. The Vigil has infiltrated them twice.
 - **The Velvet Mask (Livaea)** A secret society of patricians who worship pleasure as the only truth. Their rites are said to last nine days. No one has ever left a rite unchanged. The Vigil watches their parties and reports to the Unburnt.

Lore Echoes (CrossExpansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord run a hospice in the Shatterline Bazaar. They ask no payment but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the arena slaves, trying to untie her cord from a coinhouse debt. The Vigil has her file.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the grainprefects. Take it, and your store never runs dry but the coin will reappear in the mouth of a starving child. The Red Vigil uses it to mark debtors.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Ecktorian psions are called FlameReaders. They see the future in the Everflame’s flicker. The High Priest employs three and has never trusted a forecast that didn’t smell of smoke. The Vigil employs their apprentices.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Imperial Arena is a Class IV Poltergeist site the collective rage of every gladiator who died for the crowd. Saikou Ira would ring a bell eight times and leave a wreath of laurel. The Vigil rings the bell nine times. The Arena answers.
- **The Ninth:** In any Ecktorian court, the ninth citation of precedent voids all previous. The wise stop at eight and settle. Those who cite the ninth hear a faint laughter from the marble

walls and their cases are never heard again. The Vigil cites the ninth often. The laughter does not bother them.

Ecktoria Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Flame:** Crumble a crust into the Everflame. Ignore the first *Bread Riots* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Ribbon:** Tie a single knot in a coinhouse credit ribbon. Cancel *Frozen Purse* or take −1 die on your next debt roll (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Marble:** Whisper a dead debtor’s name into a statue’s ear. Gain +1 Effect when collecting from their heirs this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Grand Magistrate. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Spit on the Seal:** Before signing any contract, spit on the wax seal. If it sizzles, the Vigil has a copy. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **city guards or rival factions**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **crowds or ceremonial processions**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **patrols or inquisitors**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or ceremonial opportunity**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **City authorities or noble house** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **crowd movement or procession**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival faction member or city official** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **guards, mercenaries, or zealots** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes **procession turns violent/boundary dispute erupts/patron turns**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **High Priest, Grand Magistrate, or Duchess-Regent** intervenes.

- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically **procession erupts/arena gate opens/monument collapses**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice **flame speaks/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Ecktoria (Marble & Fire):** Statues turn their heads, flames burn blue, ceremonial masks appear in windows.
- **Ecktoria (Procession):** Crowds chant your name, banners block your path, trumpets announce your arrival.
- **Ecktoria (Patronage):** Seals break in your hand, favors are revoked, noble houses compete for your allegiance.
- **Ecktoria (The Vigil):** A seal appears on your documents that you did not stamp. A cough from the crowd sounds like your name. Your reflection in a polished shield has a red sash.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Cross-Region Hooks (optional draws):**
 - *Aeler True Masons bid* to shore a failing aqueduct; accepting stabilizes *Aftershock* but grants them soft leverage in the ward. The Vigil audits the contract.
 - *Aelinnel Green-Market broker* offers “truthcredit” on court gossip; pay later in favors or names. The Vigil pays in silence.
 - *Black Banner retainer* parade demands back pay on the Triumph Stairs; crowd sympathy tilts your next parley. The Vigil arrests the ringleader.
- **Faction Entanglements During Travel (use en route or on city entry):**
 - If the party holds any *Condotta* Diamonds, begin with *Bread Riots* at +1 segment (mercenary grain trains rerouted).
 - Entering with an *Underway Pass* (Aeler) grants +1 Position on *Aqueduct Walk* scenes but ticks *Ducal Conflict* once (guild jealousy). The Vigil notes your pass.
 - Carrying *Green Market* tags downgrades one *Censor’s Hall* action but flags *Inquisitorial Visit* at the next temple. The Vigil compares tags.
- **Trade Good Consequences (pick 1 when a haul sells):**
 - *Arena Steel* → street duels spike → start *Arena Spill* at 1. The Vigil collects the weapons.
 - *Relic Fragments* → basilica prestige swings → tick *Church Purge* or grant *Basilica Audience*. The Vigil inspects the relic.
 - *Survey Rights* → boundary replat → downgrade one *Border Dispute* or upgrade a rival’s. The Vigil updates the map.
- **Diplomatic Favor (minor currency):**
 - Earn by resolving a public scene without bloodshed (Forum, Procession, CoinHouse).
 - Spend 1 to reduce DV of a permit/audience by 1, or to ignore *Blocked Bridge* for one crossing.
 - Holding 2+ makes you “interesting”: start a *Red List* [4] that advances on snubbed patrons. The Vigil adds your name.

- **Reputation Echoes (soft power):**

- *Crowd-Loved (Laurel-Deed)*: first time per session you face a mob, set Position one step safer. The Vigil watches how the mob loves you.
- *Coin-House Trusted (Credit)*: ignore the first *Frozen Purse*; next time, it returns at +1 severity. The Vigil audits your credit.
- *Clerically Vouched (Everflame)*: downgrade one *Inquisitorial Visit*; if abused, promote *Church Purge*. The Vigil has a copy of your voucher.

Monuments as Mechanics (opulence with teeth)

- **Processional Geometry**: When acting on the *Triumph Stairs*, choose: +1 Effect *or* –1 Heat; on a miss, *Rerouted Triumph* advances. The Vigil stands at the top of the stairs, watching.
- **Aqueduct Leverage**: Securing an aqueduct span grants a onescene *high ground* tag in any linked ward; if collateral hits, tick *Aftershock*. The Vigil knows where the aqueduct leaks.
- **Forum Acoustics**: Rally speeches at the *Grand Forum* grant an extra assist die if at least 20 witnesses; failure spawns *Bread Riots* at +1. The Vigil counts the witnesses.

Plug-in SB Conversions (Ecktoria flavor)

- Any 1 SB may become *Crowd Drift*: shift the scene’s terrain in favor of or against you (bridges clog, stairs clear).
- Any 2 SB may become *Seal Revoked*: void one paper (Permit/Chit/Indulgence); to avert, sacrifice *Diplomatic Favor*.
- On 3+ SB offer *Patron Bargain*: accept a visible mark (ribbon, laurel brand) to halve consequences; start a *Patron Debt* [6].

Hidden Orders & Ancient Conspiracies (d12 hooks)

1. **The Ash Senate** – a ledger of “extinguished” patrician lines still voting by proxy through funerary guilds. The Vigil has the key.
2. **Surveyors of the Ninth Mile** – decumanusmasters who can *move* boundaries with ritual math; a lost rod sets precedent across the city. The Vigil owns the rod.
3. **Lantern Tetrarchy** – four basilica beadles who decide which miracles are counted; the fifth lamp was broken in a purge. The Vigil lit the purge.
4. **The Red Marble Compact** – coinhouse founders who tithe 1 in 100 coins to a secret indemnity fund used to flip coups. The Red Vigil administers the fund.
5. **Archivum Umbrae** – censor clerks maintaining a *shadow index* of names that must not stand trial (yet). The Vigil reads the index nightly.
6. **Peregrine Brotherhood** – ferrymasters trading in sealed confessions; blackmail that floats. The Vigil buys the confessions.
7. **The Laurel of Dust** – a gladiators’ mutual that chooses which champions live long enough to hold office. The Vigil chooses the champions.
8. **Aqueduct Collegium Obscura** – engineers who keep a second set of sluice keys; droughts become elections. The Vigil has the third set.
9. **Order of the Broken Obelisk** – surveycult that believes MileZero is *wrong* and can refund the city with one stone. The Vigil has the stone.

10. **The Funeral Republic** – undertakers running a parallel courier state through catacombs and wakes. The Vigil uses their couriers.
11. **The Ember Vault** – a sealed reliquary under the Arena; victors’ sweat was bottled for augury. The Vigil broke the seal.
12. **Triumphal Maskers** – procession costumers who encode heretical theses into robe pleats and torch patterns. The Vigil decodes the theses and sometimes agrees.

Cults & Mystery Rites (d10)

1. **Children of the Phoenix** (*rebirth by fire*): ashmarks grant +1 die vs. fear in crowds; mark Fatigue if you hesitate near open flame.
2. **Verdant Laurel** (*blood to marble, sap to coin*): once/session turn 1 Harm into 1 CoinHouse Credit; start a *Green Debt* [4].
3. **Mask of the Thirteenth** (*forbidden procession step*): walk through a riot unmolested; next parley with clergy begins one step worse.
4. **Brotherhood of the River Tongue** (*truth ferried at night*): ask the Dolmis one yes/no; a ferryman shows up later to collect a name.
5. **Candlemakers of Ever** (*flame remembers lies*): blue flame points to falsehood; the liar dreams of you for three nights (Exposure +1).
6. **Sable Standard** (*war saint cult*): your banner ignores morale checks once; start a *Blood-Tithe* [4] owed to the saint’s chapel.
7. **The Ninth Bell** (*hour that is not kept*): skip a queue or sentence; next edict you need arrives late (Delay SB free once).
8. **Guild of Red Accountants** (*sin as ledger*): convert 2 SB into a *Magistrate’s Postponement*; add *Karmic Debt* [6].
9. **The Marble Eaters** (*mortification sect*): bite stone, gain +1 Effect resisting crowd crush; take Harm 1 (Stress) if you boast.
10. **Torch of Saint Vessa** (*saint of necessary arson*): sanctify a fire to purge a tag (Plague/Corruption); City Heat +2.

Religious Schisms & Trials

The Everflame Divide (choose a live schism)

1. **Orthodox Basilica vs. Ember Reformers**: Is miracle *counted* by law or *kindled* by need?
2. **Laurel Theologians vs. Street Saints**: Does glory flow *down* from triumphs or *up* from breadlines?
3. **Iconoclast Ward vs. Reliquary Keepers**: Is the flame purer without images?

Schism Mechanics (table-facing)

- **Heresy Index** [0–6]: ticks when players publicize a stance, defy clergy, or wield cult rites in view. At 3: inquisitorial audits become common; at 6: *Church Purge* (Q) autotriggers once/session until lowered.
- **Sanctuary / Anathema Tags**: locations acquire tags during arc scenes. *Sanctuary*: first harm in scene becomes Fatigue; *Anathema*: first social miss spawns “Proscribed Sigil.”
- **Trial by Fire (miniprocedure, 3 beats)**:

1. *Assembly*: set the forum/stair as arena; state thesis in one sentence (players or NPCs).
2. *Witness*: three proofs (relic, miracle, precedent). Each proof: test Social/Arcana/Resolve vs. crowd DV; on success, reduce Index by 1 or gain *Basilica Audience*.
3. *Judgment*: roll Crowd Mood (1d6): 1–2 mobs, 3–4 silent acceptance, 5–6 laurel toss (gain *Laurel-Deed*). If Index ≥ 4 , –1 to the roll.

Ecktoria – Marble and Fire

Starting Location: The CoinHouse floor, marble cracked with soot lines, where votive candles burn beside melted icons.

“In Ecktoria, even faith must balance its ledgers, and the gods audit in ash.”

In... the CoinHouse floor, a factor with smokesinged ledgers offers a purse. “The Lame King moves,” she says. “And the Basilica burns with him. The Amber Palace has not answered a summons in a month. The Vigil is asking questions. I suggest you find the answers before they find you.”

Regional Motifs Coinoaths, basilica relics, marble acoustics, augury smoke, Vigil seals.

Whispers to Offer “Bid against the city,” “Pocket the relic shard,” “Name an innocent debtor,” “The Vigil’s informer sits in the corner.”

External Clocks Threat: *Procession of Ash* [6]; Community: *Credit Panic* [4]; Anchor: *Basilica Choir* [4]; Vigil: *Red List* [6].

Complications Smoke speaks truths; coins stick to skin; a reliquary runs hot; a seal appears on your documents that you did not stamp.

Anchors at Risk A choir novice; a patron account; a Vigil informer who owes you a favour.

Escalation Beat The Basilica tolls a note only one PC hears. The Vigil hears it too.

Relief Return the shard; pay a citydebt in blood or ; route the procession elsewhere; give the Vigil a name.

Boss Seeds (Cults & Conspiracies)

- **The Ember Prefect** (schismatic inquisitor): *Phase* [8] Citation → Censure → Autodafé → Purge. Lair: Everflame Cloister. Counters: relic provenance, crowdfavor, rival sermon. *Vigil twist*: The Prefect was once a Vigil informer. The Vigil knows where he hides.
- **The Surveyor-Primus** (geomantic usurper): *Phase* [6] Replat → Dispossession → Erase. Lair: MileZero. Counters: Aeler measurerods, witness line, broken rod. *Vigil twist*: The Primus has a Red Vigil agent as a protégé.
- **Phoenix of the Arena** (miracle or hoax?): *Phase* [10] Hype → Immolation → “Rebirth” → Riot. Lair: Imperial Arena. Counters: doused ash, Mask of the Thirteenth, Everflame test. *Vigil twist*: The Phoenix is a Vigil experiment. The Unburnt want to contain it. The Red Vigil wants to sell tickets.

- **The Velvet Mask** (Livaea’s cult): *Phase* [8] Invitation → Masque → Debt of Pleasure. Lair: The Amber Palace. Counters: an unbroken oath, a mirror with no reflection, a name spoken without desire. *Vigil twist*: The Vigil’s Unburnt faction attends every masque. They are not there to stop it.

Diamonds: Forbidden Leverage (add to §??)

14. **Shadow Index Leaf** – remove one name from the Red List for a week; add *Countercoup* +1.
15. **Ember Writ** – sanction one cult rite as “orthodox” for a scene.
16. **Surveyor’s Ninth Rod** – redraw one ward line unnoticed (until dawn).
17. **Vigil Seal (Red)** – For one scene, the Red Vigil treats you as a contractor. Interest will be collected later.

Cross-Contamination (fast ties)

- **Aeler True Masons**: backing an iconoclast audit grants shoring crews; bellcodes now gate temple entries. The Vigil has the bellcodes.
- **Aelinnel Thorn Courts**: hawthorn chaplains host “mirror sermons”; a basilica gains *Sanctuary* while a rival becomes *Anathema*. The Vigil watches both.
- **Black Banners**: warchaplains monetize indulgences; clearing *Payday* risks +1 *Heresy Index*. The Vigil takes a cut.

Patronage & Power

Ecktoria’s decline is not collapse, but transformation. Wealth bleeds into patronage webs: a senator’s indulgence, a censor’s indulgence, a noble’s purse. The city’s great houses keep mercenary captains on retainer, while priests sell ritual processions as public theater and private favor. And everywhere, the Vigil watches not to stop the rot, but to take notes.

Yet beneath the decay, two demons whisper. **Maelstraeus** teaches that every contract is a weapon, every debt a leash. **Livaea** teaches that every desire is a chain, every pleasure a payment. The patricians who once ruled the world now rule only the Amber Palace, and the Amber Palace is a gilded cage. They do not see the bread riots. They do not hear the Vigil’s footsteps. They dance. They drink. They forget that the flame remembers everything.

For the GM: Patronage should function as both opportunity and trap. Any gift (a purse, permit, or charter) binds the receiver to service, but patrons can die, fall from favor, or suddenly proscribe what they once allowed. The Vigil offers a different kind of patronage: *protection* in exchange for *information*. A party that pays the Vigil in secrets may find doors opening and other doors closing behind them. To emphasize the decadence and dread:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, ribbons, laurel crowns, Vigil marks) that can be stolen, forged, or voided.
- Let rival patrons issue conflicting “safeconducts,” forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use processions, funerals, or trials as arenas for social contests, where patronage debts surface and shift allegiances.
- Introduce the **Vigil’s Faction Clock** [6] to track which Vigil faction (Censer-Knights, Unburnt, Red Vigil) has the most leverage over the party. When it fills, that faction makes a demand.

Patronage in Ecktoria is not mere background it is the engine of politics, coin, and survival. And beneath it all, Maelstraeus and Livaea are writing a contract. The city is the collateral. The poor are the interest. The patricians are the signature and they signed in blood long ago.

Chapter 3

Acasia

The Broken Marches.

We do not speak of the Curse. We speak around it, under it, through the gaps where words used to fit. The Curse is not a thing. It is the space where a thing used to be.

I am a charcoal-burner. My family has worked these woods for three generations. My grandfather could name every tree between the Pale Causeway and the Wolfstairs Pass. My father could read a deer's track in packed clay. I can tell you where the villages used to be. The map in my head has more empty spaces than marks.

Acasia was not always like this. Once, the granaries held grain through winter. Once, the roads carried more than ghosts and tax collectors. Then the trees started dying. Not all at once slowly, branch by branch, forest by forest. The Blackwood turned grey, then brittle, then silent. The farmers said it was a curse. The duke said it was blight. The merchants said it was the tariffs. The priests said it was the will of gods who had stopped listening.

Nobody said it was guilt. Nobody had to. Guilt is the smell of mildew on old parchment. Guilt is the way a village watches you pass without opening its gates. Guilt is the empty chair at the feast, the unmarked grave behind the chapel, the child who will not meet your eyes because their parents told them not to speak to strangers.

The truth the one we do not speak is that we could have saved the Blackwood. We saw the first trees wither. We saw the sap run black. We did nothing. We told ourselves it would pass. We told ourselves the duke would fix it. We told ourselves the forest was not our responsibility. And then the forest died, and the silence that followed was our answer.

The Curse of Acasia is not a spell. It is a memory. The land remembers what we did and what we failed to do. Every broken milestone on the old Imperial Road is a forgotten promise. Every abandoned vineyard is a harvest we chose not to plant. Every bridge that leads back to the same shore is the road we refused to take.

Never sign a contract on a bridge. The river is a witness, and it never forgets a signature. But more than that: the bridge knows when you are lying. Not to the other party. To yourself.

We are the Curse now. We carry it in our silence, in our empty fields, in the way we turn away when someone asks where the children went. Acasia is not a broken province. It is a province that broke itself, one small refusal at a time, until there was nothing left to break but the people who stayed.

And still we stay. Because leaving would mean admitting we were wrong. And that is the one thing guilt cannot bear.

Corvin, charcoal-burner of the Blackwood, who no longer names the trees because there are too few left to name

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Hardtack soaked in broth if you have broth. If not, hardtack and hope. The granaries have been empty for three winters. The merchants sell grain at famine prices. The duke says the roads are too dangerous for caravans. The farmers say the duke owns the caravans.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To name the dead. Every Acasian child has a list of ancestors they repeat at bedtime. The list gets shorter each generation. Not because children forget. Because the dead are forgetting themselves.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Whether they have a shadow. The Curse takes shadows first. A man without a shadow is not cursed—he is already gone. His body just hasn't stopped moving yet.

What is the most common crime? Bridge-toll evasion. The roads are unsafe, the ferries are unreliable, but the barons still demand payment for crossings no one can make. The crime is not in refusing to pay. The crime is in being caught trying.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Curse began with a promise broken on the Blackwood Bridge. A baron promised his daughter to a lord of the old forest. He married her to a lowland knight instead. The forest remembered. The forest is still waiting for the wedding.

Where do people go when they die? Into the Blackwood. Burial is forbidden—the ground rejects the dead. Bodies are carried to the tree-line and left. The wood takes them. Sometimes, at dusk, you can see them walking between the trunks. They do not look back.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You walk the Broken Milea stretch of road that collapsed into the river a decade ago. If you reach the far side, you are forgiven. If you fall, you were not sorry enough. No one has reached the far side in seven years.

What is the most important festival? The Counting of the Names (midwinter). Every village lists its dead aloud, from oldest to newest. If a name is forgotten, the ghost walks until someone remembers. The list grows longer each year. The memory grows shorter.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The duke's son is a ghoul. He was lost in the Blackwood as a child. They found him three days later, pale and smiling. He does not age. He does not eat. He only watches. The servants know. The servants do not speak.

3.1 Acasia — “Broken Marches”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The Empire conquered it first. The Empire left it last. Now neither remembers why.*

Margravine of the Broken March (Elite): “The tithe must be paid, not merely offered. A promise written in ash and sealed with iron will is worth more than a thousand gold coins scattered on the wind. The Empire is dead. Its weight is not.”

Hedge-Witch (Commoner): “Don’t cross the Pale Causeway at dusk, especially not if you’ve got a silver tooth. The bridge’ll remember it, and next time you pass, it’ll want more than just your footfall. In Acasia, every road has a memory. The question is who pays the toll. The Empire forgot. That’s why it fell.”

Genre / Mood: Lowfantasy wasteland, mercenary realism, cursed borderlands.

Starting Location: The Pale Causeway’s last inn, walls sootblackened by coal and a century of gossip. A bounty poster flutters beside a halfempty hearth. The innkeeper is a oneeyed woman who pours small beer without asking. A stranger at the bar offers a sealed contract: retrieve a dowry chest from a Blackwood matriarch before the Margravine’s feast day. “The chest contains a claim, not coin,” the stranger whispers. “But a claim in Acasia is worth more than gold—it is a key to a bridge that does not loop. The Empire’s surveyors marked it. Then they died.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Acasia was the first province the Uтарan Empire swallowed when it turned its eyes east. The legions marched through the Pale Causeway, crushed the hillkings, and planted their eagles in the Blackwood. For centuries, Acasia was the empire’s eastern breadbasket and its first line of defence. Grain flowed west; coin flowed east. The roads were straight, the bridges paid, and the Curse was just a farmer’s whisper.

Then the empire rotted from within. When the last Uтарan emperor died and the provinces broke away, Acasia lingered for another hundred years a ghost province whose governors still stamped Uтарan seals, whose courts still cited Uтарan law, whose coins still bore the emperor’s face. No one came from the west to collect the taxes. No one sent legions to enforce the peace. The Acasians kept the forms, because they had never learned to keep anything else. They had no native king, no unifying faith, no common tongue beyond the legionary’s Latin. They were the empire’s children, and when the empire died, they became orphans.

For a century they clung to the ruins. Then the plagues came. Then the famines. Then the Curse a slow rot of roads that led nowhere, bridges that looped back on themselves, villages that woke to find their neighbours’ houses standing empty. The old imperial surveys became maps of places that no longer existed. The grain blights turned the storehouses to dust. The free companies, once hired to keep the peace, became the only law.

That was two hundred years ago.

Now Acasia is a wound that will not close. It sits between Ecktoria to the west and Vhasia to the east, claimed by both, ruled by neither. Petty kings raise their banners in burned keeps. Free Companies trade loyalty like grain, swapping colours midmarch. The Margravine of the Broken March keeps a tally of feuds, binding bloodlines to her feast days. The Lame King travels on a throne carried by debtors, making law by pointing. And the Curse the nameless thing that makes crossroads turn back on themselves is not a myth. It is the weight

of broken promises, and Acasia is drowning in them.

South, on the marshy islands of the Amaranthine coast, the city of Silkstrand squats on reclaimed silt, trading in silk, silver, and secrets. The Acasians call it “the Sink” a place where the Curse thins, but where law is measured in coin, not custom. Few Acasians go there. Fewer return unchanged.

What you notice first: The smell of mildew on old parchment and wet ash. The way every milestone has been recarved first in Utaran, then in a halfdozen failed scripts. The silence of a village that heard you coming and chose not to open its gates.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never sign a contract on a bridge. The river is a witness, and it never forgets a signature. The Empire’s last governor signed a treaty on the PontduTithe. No one knows what it said. The bridge remembers.

Regional Mood: Famine, Ambition, and the Ghost of Empire

Here, the past is not a memory it is a geometry. The Utaran Empire left behind roads that lead to nowhere, laws that contradict each other, and a hunger that no harvest can fill. Acasia’s petty kings hold court in burned keeps, their crowns forged from iron nails pulled from famine coffins. The Margravine keeps a tally of feuds, binding bloodlines to her feast days. Free Companies trade loyalty like grain, swapping colors midmarch. And beneath it all, the Curse waits. It is not a monster. It is a wrong turn: the bridge that leads back to the same shore, the milestone that faces the wrong direction, the bell that tolls for no funeral. In Acasia, the land itself has become a broken contract, and the fine print is written in mildew.

The Curse is not ancient. It is a legacy. Some say it began with the last Imperial Survey, when the surveyors tried to map every bridge, every ford, every tolland in the measuring, broke something. Others say it was the plagues, when the dead were buried in unmarked pits and the priests forgot the proper rites. The hedgewitches say it was the empire’s own fault: they ruled Acasia for centuries but never taught the Acasians to rule themselves. When the empire left, the land had no king, no law, no memory. The Curse filled the gap.

Now the Margravine and the Lame King fight over the scraps, while free companies sell their swords to whichever claimant pays first. The hedgewitches tie red thread around bridges and leave offerings of salt at crossroads, hoping to keep the Curse from spreading. The villagers pray to saints the Empire forgot. And the roads the old imperial roads still march west toward a capital that no longer exists. The capital does not answer. But the roads keep marching.

Prominent NPCs of Acasia

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
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Zara “ <i>the Ledger</i> ”	Margravine of the Broken March	Keep the province from fracturing completely	She has never lost a feud; her sword is also a counting rod. She claims descent from the last Utaran governor.
Oren “ <i>Tin Crown</i> ”	The Lamé King	Be recognised as a true sovereign	His traveling throne is carried by debtors; he pays them in promises. His grandfather was a free company captain who declared himself king.
Ysabeau	Hedge-Witch of the Blackwood Charcoalers	Survive the Curse and keep her kin from the rope	She knows which bridges eat travellers, and her price is a story that ends badly. Her grandmother witnessed the last imperial survey.
The Bride	Dowry chest claimant (Blackwood matriarch’s heir)	Recover the chest before the Margravine’s feast day	She carries a dagger in her wedding veil. The claim is to a bridge that drowned. The bridge was built by the Utaran legions.

Vladan	Free Company Captain (“The Rusted Banner”)	Find a permanent contract before winter	He has served three kings this year. He cannot remember their names. His company’s banner is an Utaran eagle, torn and stitched.
Sister Ash	Ex-Imperial surveyor	Finish the old map of Acasia	She visits villages that no longer exist. The map shows them anyway. She carries a sealed chest of the last governor’s papers.

Names of Acasia

Inspired by the martial duchies of a fallen southern empire: clipped Latin, warnames, and the hard consonants of mountain keeps. Many families still bear Utaranized surnames, though they have not spoken the language in generations.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Alboin	Theodelinda	da Ponte	<i>the Stiff</i>
Authari	Rosamund	del Ferro	<i>the Toll-Fist</i>
Liutprand	Gundiberga	di Rocca	<i>Bridge-Born</i>
Desiderius	Anspranda	Longobardus	<i>Blackwood</i>
Ratchis	Veleda	Saxo	<i>the Unremembered</i>
Aistulf	Gisela	Capoferro	<i>Ash-Finger</i>

(Pass/Ruin/TollTown) Broken milestone on the old Imperial Road; borders “moved” overnight. Vineterrace hillside with an abandoned press; strangler ivy owns it now.

Spades — Places

2. Broken Milestone

[*RUIN*] [*OMEN*]

On the old Imperial Road; borders “moved” overnight.

The stone has been chiseled seven times. The last mark is still wet. The first was cut by Utaran legionaries.

3. **Vine-Terrace Hillside** [RUIN] [HARVEST]
 Abandoned press; strangler ivy owns it now.
The ivy has grown around a skeleton. The skeleton still holds a wine cup. The vintage was the year the last governor left.
4. **Toll-Bridge Town** [TOLL] [BOUNDARY]
 Over a cold river; two tolls, no receipts.
The second toll is collected by a child. The child does not speak. The bridge was built by the legions. It remembers their footsteps.
5. **Wolfstairs Pass** [MOUNTAIN] [AMBUSH]
 Switchbacks beneath a stonefall cliff.
The stones were placed by a landslide that knew your name. The pass was the empire's eastern gate. No army has crossed it in a century.
6. **Sootfall Abbey Ruins** [RUIN] [DEATH]
 Bell tower intact; crypts breathing.
The breathing is a prayer. The monks are still down there. They have been praying for the empire's soul for two hundred years.
7. **Hill-Motte** [FORTIFICATION] [WAR]
 Fresh palisade; ditch scattered with caltrops.
The caltrops are from a siege that ended last week. The bodies are still rotting. The siege was over a bridge toll. The bridge has not collected in fifty years.
8. **Border-Stone Ring** [BOUNDARY] [OMEN]
 Carved with seven crowns; each points wrong.
The crowns belong to kings who never existed. The stones remember them anyway. The eighth crown was the empire's. It is not carved. It is implied.
9. **Blackwood Charcoalers' Hollow** [FOREST] [WITCHCRAFT]
 Witchposts at every path.
The witchposts were made from the gibbets of tax collectors. The tax collectors still swing. They were collecting for the empire. They have not stopped.
10. **Salt-Road Ford** [RIVER] [DEATH]
 Rains expose old bones in the chalk banks.
The bones are from three wars. They are not all human. The ford was the empire's salt route. The salt is still in the water.
- J **Iron Mine Adits** [UNDERGROUND] [WHISPERS]
 Held by a miners' commune; the air is full of whispers.
The whispers are the mine's memory. It remembers every collapse. The last collapse was the year the empire fell. The miners are still digging.
- Q **Margravine's Hunting Lodge** [NOBLE] [SECRETS]
 Tapestries of victories that never were.
The tapestries were woven by a blind weaver. The threads are from her own hair. The victories are Utaran. The weaver was Acasian.
- K **War-Camp City** [WAR] [REFUGE]
 Tents around a burned keep; every banner claims the throne.
The keep was burned by its own lord. He did not want to share the heat. The lord was the last imperial governor. He died in the fire.
- A **The Pale Causeway** [ROAD] [CURSE]
 The last high road that survives the spring thaws.

The causeway is made of bones. The bones are from the workers who built it. The workers were Acasian. The empire paid them in promises.

(Petty Crowns/Priests/Companies) Tithecollector’s runner with a tallyrod and an empty stomach; roadside prior with three lay brothers guarding a relic.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. Tithe-Collector’s Runner

[AUTHORITY] [HUNGER]

Tallyrod, empty stomach, and a list of names.

His tallyrod has notches from a dozen villages. The villages are now empty. He collects for the Margravine. She does not ask where the grain goes.

3. Roadside Prior

[FAITH] [RELIC]

Three lay brothers guarding a relic.

The relic is a finger bone. The prior claims it belonged to a saint who starved to death. The saint was an Uтарan missionary. The Acasians ate his offerings.

4. Hedge-Witch

[WITCHCRAFT] [KNOWLEDGE]

Knows which bridges eat travelers.

Her price is a story. The story must have a bad ending. She has heard all the good ones. The bridges listen when she speaks.

5. Free Company Captain

[MERCENARY] [FATIGUE]

Pike and shot between contracts.

He has served three kings this year. He does not remember their names. His first contract was with a man who called himself emperor. The man is dead. The contract is not.

6. River Reeve

[LAW] [CORRUPTION]

Rents every boat twice.

His paper is a single page folded into a boat. The other half is elsewhere. The other half is in the Margravine’s counting house. She does not know.

7. Salt-Baron

[TRADE] [VIOLENCE]

Hired blades; owns the ford and your timetable.

His salt is grey. It was cut with ashes from a burned village. The village refused to pay the imperial salt tax. The empire is dead. The salt is not.

8. Blackwood Matriarch

[NOBLE] [VENGEANCE]

Tends the feud like a garden.

Her garden grows tombstones. She waters them with tears—her enemies’. Her grandmother was the last Acasian to hold an imperial title. The empire took it back. She has not forgotten.

9. Ex-Imperial Surveyor

[KNOWLEDGE] [LONELINESS]

Has the last accurate map.

The map shows villages that no longer exist. The surveyor visits them anyway. She leaves offerings of bread and ink. The ghosts do not eat. They watch.

10. “King” of Three Villages

[CLAIMANT] [IRON]

Ironnail crown, ironwill taxes.

His crown was a plowshare. He reversed the curse. The curse reversed back. He does not know.

J Bride with No Dowry but a Claim

[CLAIM] [DESPERATION]

Daggers in the wedding chest.

The claim is to a bridge that drowned. The bride intends to collect. The bridge was built by the legions. The legions are gone. The bridge is not.

Q Margravine of the Broken March

[AUTHORITY] [FEUD]

Half saint, half tax roll.

She has never lost a feud. Her tally stick is her sword. Her greatgreatgrandfather was the last imperial governor's clerk. He stole the seal. She still has it.

K The Lame King

[CLAIMANT] [FATIGUE]

Traveling throne; makes law by pointing.

His throne is a sedan chair carried by debtors. They owe him everything. He owes the Margravine a bridge toll. He has not paid. The bridge remembers.

A The Cursed Child of Silkstrand

[MYTH] [OMEN]

A rumor more than a person; her laughter ends sieges.

She is said to be twelve years old. She has been twelve for a century. She was born on the day the last imperial governor died. She does not age. She does not forget.

(Feud/Levy/Weather/Curse) Peatfog; all horns sound like someone calling your name. Sudden levy—every traveler pressed for a day's service. Bridge feud; rival banners drop the chain on your cart.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. Peat-Fog

[WEATHER] [FEAR]

All horns sound like someone calling your name.

The name is not yours. Answer it, and the fog will take you. The fog is the empire's last breath.

3. Sudden Levy

[AUTHORITY] [TIME]

Every traveler is pressed for a day's service.

The levy master has a list. Your name is on it—in fresh ink. The list was copied from an imperial tax roll. The roll is two hundred years old.

4. Bridge Feud

[BOUNDARY] [VIOLENCE]

Rival banners drop the chain on your cart.

The chain was forged from a broken oath. It rattles when liars approach. The oath was sworn to the emperor. The emperor is dead. The chain does not care.

5. Grain Blight

[HARVEST] [FEAR]

Doubles the tithe; refusal means torches at night.

The blight has a face. It is the face of a tax collector who died hungry. The collector worked for the empire. The empire did not pay him.

6. Scree Slide

[MOUNTAIN] [BLOCKED]

Seals the pass; the "safe" detour is owned by your enemy.

The enemy raised the toll yesterday. He was expecting you. The pass was the empire's eastern gate. It still remembers the legions.

7. Wedding Turns Ambush

[SOCIAL] [TRAP]

You are caught between two bloodlines.

The bride's veil is a shroud. The groom's ring is a knife. The feud began when the empire divided the valley. The valley has not healed.

8. Witch's Tithe Night

[WITCHCRAFT] [DEBT]

Lights move in the woods; owe nothing or else.

The lights have voices. They are arguing over who should collect. They are the ghosts of imperial tax collectors. They have not stopped working.

9. **Pox Sign** [DISEASE] [ISOLATION]

On a village gate; your escorts desert you.

The pox is a rumor. The desertion is real. The pox came with the last imperial supply train. The supply train never arrived.

10. **Condotta Breaks** [MERCENARY] [BETRAYAL]

The Free Company flips colors midmarch.

The new colors are the same as the old colors. The captain just wanted to raise morale. He was hired by the Margravine. He was also hired by the Lame King. He is collecting both salaries.

J **Heretic Preacher** [FAITH] [RIOT]

Sparks a march; tollgates come down in splinters.

The preacher’s text is a tax receipt. He reads it like scripture. The receipt was issued by the empire. It is still valid. No one knows to whom.

Q **Imperial Pretender** [CLAIMANT] [POLITICS]

Arrives; every petty lord changes tabards.

The pretender’s seal is a sunburst. The sunburst is slightly crooked. The seal was stolen from the last governor’s tomb. The governor’s ghost is following him.

K **River Overruns the Levee** [WEATHER] [DESTRUCTION]

The pontoon goes; your rivals don’t.

The river’s name is “Debt.” It remembers every unpaid crossing. The empire’s engineers built the levees. They calculated the flood levels. They did not calculate the Curse.

A **The Curse Stirrs** [CURSE] [TRAP]

No matter the road, you return to the same crossroads.

The crossroads has a signpost. The arms are labeled “Regret,” “Hunger,” “The Same.” The post was planted by the last imperial surveyor. She is still walking.

(Papers/Claims/SafeConduct) Tollexemption plaque for one bridge (once); monastery letter for bed and bread on a named road.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Toll-Exemption Plaque** [TRAVEL] [ONCE]

For one bridge (once).

The plaque is a bronze leaf. Hold it up, and the tollkeeper will spit—but step aside. The leaf was minted by the empire. The empire’s mines are closed. The metal is still good.

3. **Monastery Letter** [HOSPITALITY] [ONCE]

For bed and bread on a named road.

The letter is sealed with a wax tear. The monks will honor it—or they will not. The abbot was an imperial clerk. He still follows the old forms.

4. **Wine-Right** [TRADE] [ONGOING]

On an abandoned terrace; locals will work for shares.

The wine is from a vine that grows over a mass grave. It tastes of iron. The grave holds the last imperial garrison. They were paid in promises.

5. **Condotta Contract** [MERCENARY] [ONCE]

A signed pike contract (one battle on your terms).

The contract is written in blood. The blood is from the captain's own finger. The contract was copied from an imperial legionary oath. The words have changed. The weight has not.

6. **Tithe-Remission Writ** [AUTHORITY] [ONCE]

For a village; they owe you a season's labor.

The writ is stamped with a bell. The bell's clapper is a finger bone. The bell was cast from melted imperial coinage. The coinage was debased. The bell rings true.

7. **Border-Stone Adjustment** [BOUNDARY] [ONCE]

Move a line two fields over.

The adjustment is a lie. The truth is that the line was always there. The line was surveyed by the empire's best geometers. They are all dead. Their measurements are not.

8. **Pass-Key Charm** [TRAVEL] [ONGOING]

Recognized by Pale Causeway watchmen.

The charm is a knotted cord. Untie it to pass—or to stay. The cord was tied by an imperial courier. The courier's route was swallowed by the Curse. The cord remembers the way.

9. **Sealed Dowry Chest** [CLAIM] [MYSTERY]

Of claims, not coin; certain doors open.

The chest is locked with a riddle. The answer is a name you do not know. The name is the last imperial governor's. He wrote it on the inside. He is the only one who has seen it.

10. **Mine-Share** [RESOURCE] [ALLIANCE]

In the commune; they fight like they mean it.

The share is a pickaxe. The commune will lend you a miner—or a grave. The mine was opened by the empire's first surveyors. They found iron. They also found something else. They did not name it.

J **Blood-Peace Charter** [SOCIAL] [TRUCE]

Suspend a feud long enough to move your wagons.

The charter is a white ribbon. Blood will not be spilled while it flies—but blood will remember. The ribbon was woven by a hedgewitch. She used thread from a tax collector's uniform. The collector is dead. The thread is not.

Q **Marriage Proxy** [SOCIAL] [ALLIANCE]

From the Margravine; bind a hillking to your cause.

The proxy is a wedding veil. The veil was worn by a ghost. The ghost was the Margravine's grandmother. She married an imperial legate. The legate never came home.

K **The Lame King's Traveling Writ** [AUTHORITY] [ONCE]

Troops must make way (for now).

The writ is a broken scepter. The Lame King's seal is a footprint. The footprint was pressed into wax by his grandfather. The grandfather was a free company captain. He could not write. He used his boot.

A **Curse-Redemption Rite (Temporary)** [RITUAL] [ONCE]

For one night, no crossroads can hold you.

The rite is a whisper. The whisper is a name you have never spoken. The name is the Curse's. It does not want to be spoken. It does not want to be silent. It wants to be paid.

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (papers/claims/safeconducts) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo plague and curse motifs—crossroads that turn back on themselves, bells tolling for no funeral, banners blackened by mildew, the ghost of the empire in every milestone.

Additional Features

- **Feud as Currency:** Any insult, accident, or rumor can birth a feud; the GM may replace an SB result with a feudtoken tied to a petty lord or house. Feudtokens act as reusable complications: once per scene, the GM can spend a feudtoken to have a rival appear, a bridge close, or a village refuse aid.
- **Rot & Tithe:** Each market or harvest scene carries a risk of rot—add a pressure if food or coin are exchanged without a blessing or a seal. A failed roll may double the tithe or spoil stored supplies.
- **The Curse Remembers:** When roads or negotiations stall, the GM may quietly repeat imagery—crossroads, whispers, mildew—to remind players that Acasia itself resists resolution. If the party ignores three such omens, the *Curse Stirrs* complication triggers automatically.
- **Empire’s Ghost:** Any ancient imperial structure (milestone, bridge, fortress) may still be haunted by the echo of its original purpose. A character who makes an offering (a coin, a salute, a whispered oath) may gain +1 die on a single roll within sight of that structure. The offering must be sincere. The empire does not accept bribes. It accepts memory.

Lore Echoes (CrossExpansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord run a hospice in a burned abbey. They ask no payment—but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the charcoalers, trying to untie her cord from a Rothari death warrant. She says the empire’s last weight is still unpaid.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Pale Causeway is a Class II Anchor site—the ghosts of workers who died building it still carry stones. Saikou Ira would leave a silver coin in every crack. The workers do not spend the coins. They stack them. They are building something.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the tollcollectors. Take it, and your passage is always free—but the coin will taste of blood every time the Causeway floods. The coin was minted in the empire’s last year. The emperor’s face is worn smooth.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Acasian psions are called “FeudReaders.” They taste the weight of old grudges in the water. The Margravine employs two—and has never trusted a settlement they didn’t whisper. They say the Curse is not a thing. It is a conversation. The empire is still talking.
- **The Ninth:** In any Acasian scene, the ninth toll paid at a bridge is never the last. The wise pay eight and barter for the ninth. The ninth toll is collected by a child with no name. The child is the Curse’s accountant.

Acasian Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Milestone:** Crumble a crust at a broken milestone. Ignore the first *Peat-Fog* penalty.
- **Knot the Contract:** Tie a single knot in a writ's ribbon. Cancel *Bridge Feud* or take -1 die on your next negotiation (your choice).
- **Name to the Blight:** Whisper a dead tax collector's name into a grain sack. Gain +1 Effect when avoiding tithes this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Margravine.

Decline & Patronage

Patronage here is as brittle as candle wax. The Rothari Clan holds their marches by fear and iron law—patronage from them is real, but cruel, demanding service in blood or levy. Elsewhere, noble names are little more than titles printed on parchment and sold like promises. The Margravine keeps a tally of feuds, binding bloodlines to her feast days, while mercenary captains trade loyalty for coin, switching colors with each bell.

To seek a patron in Acasia is to choose which hunger you will feed: the Rothari's iron teeth, a Free Company's purse, or the hollow blessing of a saint who may never have lived. Yet even false crowns cast shadows long enough to shelter those desperate enough to kneel. The empire is dead. Its weight is not. And the Curse is patient.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **tithe-collectors or petty lords**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **Free Company patrols or village watchmen**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **feud-trackers or hedge-witches**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable road conditions**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **River reeve or Free Company captain** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **fog or bridge closure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival bloodline or toll-lord's enforcer** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **feudkin, Free Company deserters, or Margravine's guards** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **contract voided/levy doubled/curse triggered**.

- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** Margravine, **Lame King**, or **Cursed Child** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **fog thickens/bridge falls/curse loops**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Acasia (Feud & Tithe):** Toll collectors demand double, bloodlines take offense, wagons are seized as “payment.”
- **Acasia (Rot & Famine):** Grain blights spread, wells run dry, abandoned villages hold only ghosts.
- **Acasia (Curse & Crossroads):** Roads loop back, milestones point the wrong way, the same bridge appears twice.
- **Acasia (Empire’s Ghost):** A phantom legionary marches past, an imperial seal glows on a broken stone, a tax collector’s ghost demands arrears.

Boss Archetypes in Acasia

- **The False King (Feud/Authority)** — A petty lord or pretender who crowns themselves on the ruins of empire. *Phases:* Levy Demanded → Feud Declared → Hasty Coronation. *Cracks:* a **Blood-Peace Charter** suspends his authority; a **Marriage Proxy** binds him to a rival.
- **The Witch of the Blackwoods (Witchcraft/Curse)** — A hedgewitch, matriarch, or revenant who manipulates feuds and curses. *Phases:* Tithe of Fear → Curse of the Crossroads → Hollow Wedding. *Cracks:* a **Curse-Redemption Rite** breaks her hold; a **Mine-Share** gives the commune courage to defy her.
- **The Tithe Collector (Greed/Extortion)** — A bureaucratpriest with writs, escorts, and the ability to summon feuds or famine with a single decree. *Phases:* Audit of Souls → Seizure of Grain → The Reckoning. *Cracks:* a **Toll-Exemption Plaque** voids his claim; a **Wine-Right** buys off his debtors.
- **The Rotting Child (Mystery/Curse)** — A folkloric horror tied to Acasia’s plague of false crossroads. *Phases:* Laughter in the Fog → The Bridge That Loops → The Feast of Ends. *Cracks:* a **Tithe-Remission Writ** fed to the fog; a **Monastery Letter** read aloud at the crossroads.
- **The Imperial Ghost (Undead/Precedent)** — The shade of the last imperial governor, still trying to collect the taxes. *Phases:* Audit of the Damned → Summon the Debtors → The Emperor’s Peace. *Cracks:* produce the original imperial charter (in the Sealed Dowry Chest), pay a wergild in the empire’s own debased coinage, or convince the ghost that the empire is truly dead.

Encounter Seeds (Quick Hooks)

- **The Dowry That Walked:** A Blackwood matriarch's dowry chest has been stolen. The chest contains a claim to a bridge that never floods—and a curse that the Margravine wants broken. The chest was last seen in the hands of a free company captain who claims he is the heir to the empire.
- **The Lame King's Feast:** The Lame King invites the party to a feast. The feast is a trial. The food is memory. The wine is lies. The king wants to know who killed the last imperial surveyor. The surveyor is sitting at the table.
- **The Curse of the Pale Causeway:** The Causeway is repeating. Every crossing brings the party back to the same inn. The innkeeper is missing a finger. She says she gave it to the bridge. The bridge wants more. The bridge remembers the empire's last toll.

Chapter 4

Vhasia

The Fractured Sun.

Two crowns. One kingdom. A river so wide it might as well be a border and oh, how the crowns love pretending it's not.

I am a Road Warden. I have served under three different banners on this same stretch of road, and the only constant is that someone always wants to collect tolls. The Northern Seigneurie and the Southern Parlement both claim the throne, both flood the river with paperwork to "prove" their right, and both are too busy arguing over seal wax colours to notice that the Fenwoods already burned Lence, and the Sun-court is a memory.

The Last Dauphin? A rumour. But rumours pay well when you're the one who started them and I started three: that he was swapped at birth with a goatherd's child, that he's secretly a Veiled Sister in disguise, and that he's been dead for ten years, his "reappearance" a puppet show run by the Seigneurie's spymaster.

Never carry a coin that bears only one sunburst. The realm has three mints, and the wrong metal on the wrong road is treason.

Road Warden Cerran, who has not slept in two days and is not sure which crown he serves

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Dark bread and watered wine the wine cuts the dust from the road. The nobility eat spiced eggs and fresh cheese, but they eat behind closed doors. To eat well in public is to invite envy. Envy is a dagger.

What does a child learn before they can walk? Which colours not to wear. Black and gold are the Northern Crown's colours. Red and silver are the Southern Parlement's. A child

who wears the wrong colour to the wrong village may not return home.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Which side of the road they walk on. The north side is the Crown's. The south side is the Parlement's. The middle is no man's land literally. Bandits, spies, and messengers use the middle. So do ghosts.

What is the most common crime? Raiding across the Belworth. The river is the border, the border is a suggestion, and the suggestion is enforced by armed men on both sides. The crime is not in raiding. The crime is in being caught on the wrong bank at dawn.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Sun-court was not burned. It was bankrupted. The Fenwoods did not sack Lencethey bought it. Every judge, every clerk, every guard captain had a price. The Fenwoods paid it. The Vhasians are still paying interest.

Where do people go when they die? To the crypts beneath the Sun-court if they can afford a plaque. The poor are buried in unmarked graves along the Belworth floodplain. The river floods every spring. The dead wash downstream, into the land of the other crown. Neither side claims them.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a chevauchée a raiding party that burns a village in your name. The apology is not in the burning. The apology is in the promise that the village will be rebuilt with your own hands. If you burn a village and do not rebuild, you have not apologized. You have started a feud.

What is the most important festival? The Sun-return (spring equinox). Both crowns claim the sun as their symbol. On this day, both hold processions. The processions are identical. The participants do not acknowledge each other. The sun does not care.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Queen-Mother has no claim to the regency. Her son is not the Dauphin. The real Dauphin died in childbirth. The Queen-Mother's daughter was stillborn. The child on the throne is a foundling, bought from a Tulkani caravan. The Tulkani know. The Tulkani are still waiting to be paid.

4.1 Vhasia — “The Fractured Sun”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The sun shattered at Lence. The pieces are still falling. Which shadow will catch you?*

Cardinal-Regent of the Broken Sun (Elite): “The sun may be fractured, but our authority is absolute within our domains. Every coin minted here carries our blessing, and every law written bears our seal the rest is just politics. The rest is also ash. Ask the Fenwoods. They made the ash, and they left us to choke on it.”

Road Warden (Commoner): “I’ve served under three banners on this same road. The only constant is that someone always wants to collect tolls, oaths, the dead. The Fenwoods burned Lence ten years ago. Now every duke with a purse thinks he’s king. The QueenMother weaves, Valdaish sharpens, and the Two Crowns count their silver. Me? I just want to get home before the snows bury the graves.”

Genre / Mood: Courtly intrigue, chevauchée warfare, fractured legitimacy, the tragedy of chivalry a kingdom that cannot mourn because mourning would mean admitting the old world is dead.

Starting Location: The PontduTithe, its golden arches catching fire in the sunset as pilgrims chant from both banks. A Duchy Constable in splendid armor guards the toll gate. “The Chevauchee burns,” he says, gesturing to distant smoke. “Two Crowns march to meet it. Whose seal do you carry? Speak quickly the levy waits for no one. And keep your hand away from your sword. The bridge remembers the last blood spilled here. It remembers the Fenwood horses. It remembers the screams.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Vhasia is a realm of broken coronations and split loyalties, still bleeding from a wound a decade old. Once a proud province of the Utaran empire, the unified Suncourt shattered like its heraldic sunburst when the Fenwoods of Viterra and their allies sacked the capital of Lence and cast down the old Blood line. Duke Braedyn Fenwood uncle of Veralyn, now the Warrior Queen of Viterra led the assault, his ironshod cavalry grinding the Sunking’s army into the mud of the Ford of Ashes. They burned Lence until the mirrors melted and the very stones wept. They left the throne empty not destroyed, but open. And they left a wound that has not healed.

The memory of the sack haunts every negotiation. The QueenMother, Elianor Everblood (née Longblood), lost her third husband the old Sunking and her cousins and sisters in the flames. Her second son, Wyllmot, King of Viterra and Duke of Aberiel, died fighting rebels in Viterra, leaving his crown to his daughter, Veralyn who is now the Warrior Queen, who was the Fenwoods’ ward, and who was there when they burned Lence. Elianor rules from a riverside keep, weaving alliances and hiding a secret a Dauphin, perhaps her grand-nephew, perhaps a changeling, who may be the key to restoring the Suncourt. Her eldest son, Valdaish Longblood, Duke of Adria, claims the throne by blood and steel, but Elianor does not trust him. She has outlived three husbands and two sons. She is not mourning. She is *waiting*. The Fenwood sack was not just a military defeat; it was a betrayal of chivalry itself. The knights of Vhasia had sworn to protect the realm with the Round of Five Virtues: Courage, Courtesy, Mercy, Prowess, Truth. At Lence, the Fenwoods showed no mercy. The knights

still argue about whether chivalry died there or whether it was already a corpse, dressed in armor. The Cantor Alain sings the *Planctus Armatus* each spring, and the congregation weeps for Sir Corin, who unbuckled his gorget to hear a thief's voice and was undone by the mercy he offered. Sir Corin died at Lence. He was trying to save a child. The child is now the Dauphin or so the QueenMother claims.

Now rival dukes, duchesses, abbesses, and parlements claim the fractured light. Everywhere, signs of fracture: chipped sundiscs on milestones, worn tabards bearing half a crown, coins minted in rival cities with different suns. In Vhasia, legitimacy is as fragile as a mirror, and every oath risks breaking along the fault lines of politics, faith, and fortune. The two Crowns

Valdais Longblood of Adria in the south-west, and a rival claimant backed by the southern parlements march their levies through fields that can feed neither. Routiers sell their swords by the season, and parlement clerks drown justice in procedure. Vhasia is not a nation at war. It is a nation that forgot how to be at peace and that has not yet learned how to grieve.

What you notice first: The smell of old smoke and fresh ink. The way every noble's seal has a hairline crack. The constant, nervous laughter of courtiers who remember whose head rolled last season. The way the knights touch their gorgets when someone speaks of mercy.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never carry a coin that bears only one sunburst. The realm has three mints, and the wrong metal on the wrong road is treason. Also, never speak the name "Fenwood" without naming Queen Veralyn first. The wound is still raw. The QueenMother's spies are everywhere and they have long memories.

Regional Mood: Crowns, Courts, and the Weight of Lence

Here, the past is a weapon and the future is a debt not of silver, but of memory. The Fenwoods came from Viterra with fire and iron, broke the Sunking's army at the Ford of Ashes, and burned Lence until the mirrors melted. Duke Braedyn Fenwood led them; his daughter Veralyn now the Warrior Queen of Viterra was his wife's attendant and witness to the sack, a fact that complicates every border negotiation. The Vhasian nobility has not forgotten. They cannot forgive. But they cannot afford a war with Viterra, either.

So they fight each other instead.

Now every duke with a long purse and a short conscience backs a claimant. The QueenMother weaves alliances from her riverside keep, holding a Dauphin perhaps her grand-nephew, perhaps a commoner with a convincing birthmark as a bargaining chip. The Two Crowns Valdais Longblood of Adria in the south-west, and a rival claimant backed by the southern parlements march their levies. Routiers sell their swords by the season, and parlement clerks drown justice in procedure. Vhasia is not a nation at war. It is a nation that forgot how to be at peace. And ten years later, the smoke from Lence still hasn't cleared.

The Players of the Great Game

The succession crisis has four major factions, each with a claim, a secret, and a price.

- **QueenMother Elianor Everblood (née Longblood):** Widow of the last Sunking, mother of Valdais and the late Wyllmot. She rules the western canton of Ethor. Her price is a guarantee that her grand-nephew (the Dauphin) will not be killed. Her secret: she is not sure if the child is truly of the Blood but she acts as if he is, because certainty would destroy what remains of the Longblood line.

- **Duke Valdais Longblood of Adria:** The northern claimant. Nephew or halfbrother, depending on the rumor to the last Sunking. A tournament champion with a flawless record and a suspicious habit of opponents falling ill before jousts. His claim rests on blood and steel. His secret: his mother, Elianor, does not trust him. He was not at Lence. He wishes he had been so he could have died with honor instead of living with doubt.
- **The Two Crowns (Rival Dukes of the South and West):** Backed by the southern parlements and the western march lords. Their claim rests on election and expediency. Their secret: they have been known to accept Viterran gold but never the Fenwood seal. They whisper that Veralyn is not her father’s daughter. They are wrong. They are also afraid.
- **The Last Dauphin (The False/Real Heir):** A child of nine years, hidden in the QueenMother’s keep. His legitimacy is a matter of faith. His existence is the only thing keeping Valdais from marching on his mother’s castle. His secret: even Elianor does not know if he is truly her grand-nephew but she has dreamed of Sir Corin, who died saving a child at Lence. The child in the dream has the Dauphin’s face.
- **Queen Veralyn of Viterra (offstage):** The Warrior Queen, granddaughter of Elianor, niece of Valdais. She holds the eastern canton of Aberiel as Duchess, a bitter fruit of the Fenwood conquest. She does not press a claim on the Suncourt she already has a crown. But her shadow falls long across the Belworth, and the Vhasian claimants measure every word against the chance that she might ride again. Her secret: she was at Lence. She saw what her father did. She has not forgiven him or herself.

Prominent NPCs of Vhasia

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Elianor Everblood	QueenMother of Ethor	Restore her grand-nephew (real or false) to the throne	She has out-lived three husbands and two sons. She is not mourning she is planning. Her third son, Valdais, does not know she keeps a letter from Wyllmot, written the night before he died.

Valdais Longblood	Duke of Adria, claimant	Unite Vhasia under a strong northern crown	He has never lost a joust. His opponents have a habit of falling ill before the tilt. He does not poison them. His mother's spies do.
The Red Marshal	Exiled commander of the Suncourt's army	Win back Lence or die trying	He lost the Battle of Ashes; he still sees it in his dreams and his nightmares. He was there when the Fenwoods broke the line. He was the last man to see the old king alive. The king's last words were a curse on the Fenwood name.
Seint Michel's Justiciar	Magistrate of the Order of the Gilded Scale	Enforce the chivalric code without mercy	He carries a scale with one pan empty; the empty pan is for lies. He has never been able to balance it. The empty pan holds the ghost of Sir Corin.

Sister Oria	Custodian of the LanternRites House on the Belworth	Keep the rites of hospitality and witness	She has never drawn a blade. She has never needed to. The QueenMother’s enemies who cross her threshold have a habit of forgetting why they came. Her ledger records every name and every debt of those who died at Lence.
The Cantor Alain	Iron Bard, bearer of the Cracked Ring	Sing the truth of Corin’s mercy before the armor closes again	Feathers grow from his temples; his shadow moves a halfstep behind him. His songs are the only honest history left in Vhasia. He sings the names of the dead every dusk. The dead listen.

The (Child)	Dauphin	A child of nine, hidden in the QueenMother's keep	Survive	He has never seen the sun. He knows three languages, the lineage of every noble house, and the taste of every poison. He does not know if he is a prince or a puppet. He dreams of a knight with an unbuckled gorget.
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Names of Vhasia

Inspired by the fractured duchies: Francien, Norman, and Brittonic influences. Soft vowels, silent consonants, and surnames that recall a bridge, a ford, or a stained banner.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Valdais	Eliador	de la Marche	<i>the Iron</i>
Renaud	Isabeau	de Lence	<i>the Unbuckled</i>
Corin	Oria	d'Aethor	<i>BellSworn</i>
Touénot	Mael	du Pont	<i>the Silver</i>
Alain	Giselle	de la Croix	<i>AshBanner</i>
Ghiro	Celandine	l'Argent	<i>the Unpaid</i>

(Château/Cathedral/Forest) Wayside shrine with pilgrims tacking petitions to a scorched sundisc; vineterraced clos above a millstream with napping watchmen.

Spades Places

2. **Wayside Shrine** — Pilgrims tack petitions to a scorched sundisc; each parchment curls in different winds. *The petitions are never answered. The shrine is a mailbox for the dead especially those who fell at Lence. The dead do not write back. They wait.*
3. **Vine-Terrace** — Clos above a millstream; watchmen nap, halberds traded for bottles. *The best vintage is called "Crownbreaker." It tastes like smoke and regret. The year of the sack was a particularly good harvest. The wine remembers.*
4. **Bastide Square** — Neat as a checkerboard; merchants pay homage to different "hours" of the Sun. *The square has a gallows. It rotates to face whichever claimant lost the last duel. The wood is still green from the forest where the Fenwoods camped before Lence.*

5. **Royal Forest** — Antler posts mark laws no king remembers; poachers still hang. *The forest’s deer have grown bold. They wear crowns of shed antlers. Some say they are the ghosts of the old nobility or the knights who unbuckled their gorgets too late.*
6. **Pont-du-Tithe** — Tollbridge flanked by chapels and crossbows; chains blessed by rival bishops. *The chains were forged from melted sunbursts. They ring in different keys. The Fenwood army crossed here. The bridge still groans when Viterrans approach. The groans are prayers.*
7. **Great Fair** — Outside a chartered town; counting sheds ring like bells, rumors louder still. *The fair has a Court of Miracles where counterfeaters sell to informers. The best forgery is a sunburst coin that rings true until you test its weight. The weight of a lie is memory.*
8. **Salt Pans** — Windpumps on an estuary; gulls own the law, smugglers own the night. *The salt is grey. It tastes of old tears and older debts. The smugglers carry more than salt they carry the QueenMother’s letters. The letters smell of Lence.*
9. **Siege-Château** — Hoardings patched, cistern low, banners cut into ragged suns. *The banner’s ragged edges are from a Fenwood sword. The owner still limps. He lost his son at Lence. He fights for Valdais but he does not love him. He loves the ghost of his son.*
10. **Cathedral Yard** — Cranes creak, stones fly, scaffolds bristle with rival masons’ marks. *The mason’s marks are clan signs. A scratchedout mark means a dead foreman. One mason’s mark is a sunburst with a crack the mark of the QueenMother’s architect. He was at Lence. He built the pyres.*
- J **Parlement Hall** — Hung with faded tapestries; sunbursts spliced and restitched by claimants. *The tapestries show battles that never happened and some that shouldn’t have. One tapestry shows the sack of Lence from the Fenwood perspective. The QueenMother has ordered it burned three times. It keeps reappearing. The thread is from the shrouds of the dead.*
- Q **Queen’s Causeway** — Milelong oath paved in quarried stone; halfsunken each spring. *The sunken half is a graveyard for vows. The stones are slippery with old lies. The QueenMother walks here at dawn. She speaks to the dead. The dead answer in the voice of the Dauphin.*
- K **Sun Palace (Lence)** — Shattered mirrors, brambled gardens; courtiers playing at kingship. *The mirrors were covered after the sack. No one wants to see what they show now a reflection of a kingdom that no longer exists. The courtiers pretend the king still lives. The servants know better. The mirrors know best.*
- A **King’s High Road** — Milestones chipped of crowns; yet every army still marches it. *The road is paved with the bones of tax collectors. They are not missed. The Fenwood army marched here. Their footprints are still visible in the stone and in the memory of every orphan.*

(Lord/Court/Company) Road warden with dented badge and honest horn; vintnerguild syndic counting saints’ days as credit terms.

Hearts People & Factions

2. **Road Warden** — Dented badge, honest horn; ignored by both crowns but knows the roads. *His horn is cracked. It still sounds but the note is always half a step flat. He was at Lence. He does not speak of it. The horn does.*
3. **Vintner Syndic** — Counts saints’ days as credit terms, vintages as treaties; wine as diplomacy. *He keeps a bottle of Crownbreaker in every cellar. He knows which vintage each duke prefers. He also knows which duke’s wine is poisoned. He does not ask. The poison is memory.*

4. **Abbess-Chatelaine** — Rules a fortressconvent with iron accounts and sharper scripture. *She has never drawn a blade. The scaffold has, on her orders. She sheltered refugees after the sack. The QueenMother owes her a debt. The QueenMother does not forget debts or the smell of burning wool.*
 5. **Routier Captain** — Scarred and mercenary; prefers ransoms to loyalty; coin as conscience. *He switches banners as often as his shirt. His loyalty is to the paychest and his mother. He fought for the Fenwoods at Lence. He still has nightmares. He pays for them in silver.*
 6. **Duchy Constable** — Splendid armor, empty coffers, pride swollen as a banner; glory over gold. *His armor was his grandfather's. It still has the dent from a Fenwood axe. He serves Valdaïs because Valdaïs pays but he served the old king first. He cannot forgive himself for surviving Lence. The dent weeps rust.*
 7. **Parlement Clerk** — Drowns foes in procedure, fishes them out for fealty; law as a weapon. *His quill is a dagger. He sharpens it every morning. He keeps a list of who voted for which claimant. The list is written in disappearing ink. Only he knows the reagent. The reagent is the memory of Lence.*
 8. **Salt-Farmer** — Gabelle lessee with cudgels, writs, and a riverchart no crown has; tax as tyranny. *His ledger is written in salt. One drop of water and the debts vanish along with the evidence. He is the QueenMother's man. He does not say so aloud. His salt tastes of ash.*
 9. **Trouvère** — A scandalous lay about the last Sunking brings knives to tavern doors. *He sings the truth. That is why he sleeps in a different inn every night. He knows who really ordered the burning of Lence. He will not say. He values his tongue. The truth is a currency he spends in silence.*
 10. **Marshal-Exile** — The Suncourt's hammer; now wielded by whoever pays in silver. *He lost the Battle of Ashes. He still sees it in his dreams and his nightmares. He was the last man to see the old king alive. The king's last words were a curse on the Fenwood name. The curse is still unpaid.*
- J **Heretic Perfect** — Preaches peace while tucking hidden daggers into parchment margins. *His sermon is a code. The psalms tell you which bridge to cross and which to burn. He is the QueenMother's spy. He is also Valdaïs's spy. He is also his own spy. His sermons are the only honest prayers left.*
- Q **Queen-Mother** — Riverside keep; weaves alliances as if they were dowers. *She has outlived three husbands and two sons. She is not mourning. She is waiting. Her grand-nephew real or false will sit on the Suncourt. She will not live to see it. She has made her peace with that. The peace tastes of Lence.*
- K **Two Crowns** — Rival dukes, each "crowned" in rival cathedrals, neither whole. *One wears a crown of iron. The other wears a crown of words. Both rust. Neither was at Lence. Neither speaks of it. They pay others to speak for them.*
- A **Last Dauphin** — A rumor with a birthmark; armies march for whispers alone. *He may be a baker's son. The armies don't care. They need a sun to follow. He has never seen the sun. He knows three languages, the lineage of every noble house, and the taste of every poison. He does not know if he is a prince or a puppet. He does not ask. He dreams of a knight with an unbuckled gorget. The knight's name is Corin.*

(Chevauchée/Law/Church) Chevauchée burning loyalty oaths as well as barns; smoke curls like scripture. Interdict falls on a county; bells silenced, trade stalls.

Clubs Complications/Threats

2. **Chevauchée** [WAR] [RAID] — Raiders burn loyalty oaths as well as barns; smoke curls like scripture. *The raiders wear no colors. Their horses answer to whistles and grudges. They were at Lence. They remember. The smoke smells of old wool.*
3. **Interdict** [RELIGIOUS] [LEGAL] — Falls on a county; bells silenced, trade stalls, heretics prosper. *The bells were melted for shot three wars ago. The silence is old. The interdict was ordered by the Cardinal-Regent but no one knows which claimant he serves. The silence is a prayer for the dead of Lence.*
4. **Forest Law** [LEGAL] [HUNT] — Venison becomes treason; poachers hang from antler posts. *The antler posts are carved with the names of the hanged. They whisper at dusk. The names include survivors of Lence who could not find work. The whispers are the names of the dead they could not save.*
5. **River Spate** [WEATHER] [DELAY] — Ferries chained, bridges drowned, pilgrims stranded midprayer. *The water is the color of old gold. It washed away a mint last spring. The mint belonged to a claimant who could not pay his routiers. The routiers now raid for the other side. The water remembers the gold.*
6. **Coin Debasement** [ECONOMY] [LEGAL] — Three mints, three suns, no trust; soldiers demand silver alone. *The silver is from the same mine but the stamp is a prayer, not a promise. The QueenMother controls two mints. Valdais controls one. The Cardinal-Regent holds the dies. The dies were made from melted Fenwood spurs.*
7. **Parlement Divided** [LEGAL] [POLITICS] — A siege laid on parchment before walls; war by paperwork. *The clerks duel with citations. The loser pays the winner’s ink bill. The winner gets to draft the next round of tax levies. The peasants pay both. The ink is mixed with ash from Lence.*
8. **Company Mutiny** [WAR] [MERCENARY] — Unless arrears are paid in blood or coin; mercenaries as a time bomb. *The mutineers have a list. Your name is on it or will be by nightfall. The list was leaked by the QueenMother’s spy. She wants the routiers to switch sides. The list is written on a page torn from the Chivalric Ledger.*
9. **Relic Dispute** [RELIGIOUS] [LEGAL] — Two abbeys claim the same saint’s bones; mobs answer with stones. *The bones are actually from a cow. The saints don’t mind. They like the attention. The abbeys are backed by rival claimants. The cow was from a farm that burned at Lence. The cow’s ghost haunts both abbeys.*
10. **Harvest Blight** [ECONOMY] [WEATHER] — Bread locked behind pikes; bakers guarded as lords. *The blight has a name. It is the name of a duke who raised the levy too late. His fields fed the Fenwood army. His people starved. He still rules. The blight is his guilt made visible.*
- J **Tournament “Accident”** [CHIVALRY] [ASSASSINATION] — Hides an assassination; your favor is now evidence. *The lance was filed with a prayer. The prayer was answered but not for the target. The victim was a claimant’s champion. The killer was never found. The QueenMother smiled. The lance was from Lence.*
- Q **Royalist Restoration** [POLITICS] [FEAR] — Sunburst badges painted overnight on doors and graves. *The paint is the color of dried blood. The badges face the wrong direction. The QueenMother’s agents paint them. She wants the people to remember that the Suncourt once existed. The badges glow in moonlight.*
- K **Feudal Levy** [WAR] [LEGAL] — Lords demand levies in days, not months, with three days’ bread. *The bread is hardtack from the last Fenwood siege. It still smells of smoke. The levy*

was called by Valdais. The lords are his cousins. They do not want to march. They owe him. The bread is also a memory.

- A **Winter Campaign** [WEATHER] [WAR] — Roads turn to mud, hooves to ice, armies to ruin. *The snow is grey with ash. The Pass of Ashes has a sister pass now. The Fenwood army marched through the Pass of Ashes. The ghosts still march there in both passes. The snow tastes of salt.*

(**Charter/Patent/Right**) Safeconduct sealed by a duke or abbey; honored only once, on one road; burgess charter for a market ward.

Diamonds Rewards/Leverage

2. **Safe-Conduct** *The seal is cracked. The road is watched. Use it before the seal breaks. The seal was cracked at Lence by a Fenwood axe.*
 3. **Burgess Charter** *The charter is a bell. Ring it, and the town answers or it doesn't. The bell was cast from a melted sunburst. It rings true but only for those who remember. The bell's clapper is a finger bone from a knight who died at Lence.*
 4. **Bridge Farm** — Tolls at PontduTithe for a season, if you can hold it. *The tollkeepers are loyal to the last coin. Yours or theirs. The bridge was rebuilt after Lence. The stone is new. The ghosts are old. The ghosts do not pay tolls.*
 5. **Paréage Charter** — Shared rule with a monastery half justice, half rent, no peace. *The monks pray for you. They also pray for your enemies. Balance. The monastery sheltered refugees after the sack. The QueenMother has not forgotten. The monks' prayers smell of smoke.*
 6. **Wardship** — Over a minor heir; lands obey you "for now." *The heir has a knife. He knows how to use it. He learned from watching you. His father died at Lence. He does not know which side his father fought for. He does not care. The knife was his father's.*
 7. **Gabelle Lease** — Salttax rights; lucrative, hated, and dangerous. *The lease is a death warrant written in profit. Cash it wisely. The salt pans are near the Belworth. The Vhasian border is close. The Fenwood raids come at dawn. The salt is grey with ash.*
 8. **Letters Patent** — Raise a freecompany under your banner; an army as a business. *The letters are signed in blood yours or the notary's. Both are valid. The notary lost a hand at Lence. He signs with his left. His right is buried in Lence. The blood is still warm.*
 9. **Remission** — Of feudal dues for a village; they'll march when called. *The village has a long memory. They remember the last lord who promised mercy. He was a Fenwood. They do not forgive. The remission is written on a page torn from the Chivalric Ledger.*
 10. **Low-Justice** — Grant (stocks, fines, gallows) in a troublesome hamlet. *The gallows rope is new. The notches are from the last hamlet. The hamlet was burned by routiers. The routiers were paid by a claimant. The claimant denies it. The rope was spun from the shrouds of Lence.*
- J **Confiscation Writ** — Against a royalist estate if you can seize it first. *The writ is a race. The other claimant rides a faster horse. The estate belonged to a lord who died at Lence. His widow still lives there. She has a knife. The knife is for the horse.*
- Q **Queen's Audience** — Private with the QueenMother; a whisper becomes policy. *The audience is a chess game. She always wins but she lets you take a pawn. The pawn is the Dauphin. Do not touch him. His shadow is not his own.*

K Sunburst Warrant — Of the fallen court most still bow if shown boldly. *The warrant is a ghost. It has no power only the power of belief. The ghost was signed by a dead king. The dead king’s seal was stolen from his tomb. The QueenMother has the original. The original weeps wax.*

A General Pardon — Temporary: rebels absolved if they bend the knee. *The pardon is a spring. It will close when the season turns. The rebels were at Lence. They fought for the old king. They fled when the Fenwoods broke the line. They are still running. The pardon smells of ash.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (charters/patents/rights) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **fractured sun** motifs light that splinters, oaths that crack like glass, smoke that smells of Lence, and a child who may be a prince or a puppet. Also echo the weight of memory: a ghost knight, a mirror that shows the sack, a bell that rings for the dead.

Additional Features

Fractured Seals: When brandishing a writ, badge, or charter tied to a Suncourt claimant, step Position up one step for the scene’s next interaction at a gate, court, or checkpoint. Each use advances a **Legitimacy** [4] clock linked to the claimant; when it fills, rivals challenge the authority on sight. The seal’s crack widens with each challenge. Eventually, it will break and the broken seal will smell of Lence.

Parlement Games: If a scene touches petitions, guild disputes, or feudal appeals, the first Diamond played becomes a policy lever: treat it as two Diamonds toward swaying a decision or rewriting a custom. Afterward, start or advance a **Whispered Precedent** clock; when it fills, backlash spreads as other courts cite the case against you. The QueenMother’s clerks are masters of this. They have never lost because they have never forgotten the price of losing. The price is Lence.

Gabelle Knife-Edge: At bridges, fairs, or salt depots, convert Diamonds tied to tolls, leases, or safeconducts into immediate passage or tariff relief for the company (no roll). Each conversion ticks a **Resentment** [4] clock for the locale; when it completes, expect boycotts, ambush rumors, or an audit by rival officials. The salt farmers remember Lence. They do not forget. The salt in their tears is grey.

Vhasian Chivalry & the Round of Five Virtues: The knights of the western cantons (Ethor, Adria) follow the Round of Five Virtues: **Courage, Courtesy, Mercy, Prowess, Truth**. In a formal joust or a legal duel, the GM may award *Victory by Virtue* rather than by blood: the combatant with the higher Virtue score wins the dispute, even if they lost the physical exchange. This is the law of the tilt and the law of the court. But at Lence, the Fenwoods showed no mercy. The knights still argue about whether chivalry died there or whether it was already a corpse dressed in armor.

The Armor Closes / The Song Escapes (Chivalric Clocks): The Cantor Alain, bearer of the Cracked Ring, sings a warning at every tourney:

- **Armor Closes [6]** advances when knights choose protection over mercy, when gorgets are buckled tight, when chivalry becomes siege mentality. When full, the cantons close their borders and the raids become wars. The Fenwoods taught Vhasia that mercy is a weakness. The knights have not forgotten. They wear their gorgets to bed.
- **Song Escapes [8]** advances when a Cantor sings the truth, when mercy is shown, when armour is unbuckled. When full, a moment of genuine connection occurs though it may be fatal. The Cantor Alain has been trying to fill this clock for ten years. He is still trying. He sings every dusk. The dead listen.

In Rouen, Alain still sings the *Planctus Armatus* each spring, and the congregation weeps for Sir Corin, who unbuckled his gorget to hear a thief's voice and was undone by the mercy he offered. Sir Corin died at Lence. He was trying to save a child. The child is now the Dauphin or so the QueenMother claims. The child has never seen the sun. He dreams of an unbuckled gorget every night.

Lore Echoes (CrossExpansion Hooks)

- **Seint Michel, the Judge of the Scar (Mykkiel):** The Order of the Gilded Scale maintains the *Chivalric Ledger* a record of every oath sworn and broken in the cantons. A page torn from this ledger can serve as a singleuse Claim String (gain +1 Position in any court). The Order's justiciars are feared and respected; they never unbuckle their gorgets, and they have never lost a case. The QueenMother keeps a copy in her riverside keep, wrapped in a grey shroud. The page that records the Fenwood oath of safe passage broken at Lence is still blank. The Order will not write it. They are afraid of what will happen if they do. The blank page smells of smoke.
- **Seint Isabeau, Who Slumbers Amongst the Lilies (Ikasha):** In the Ethorian marches, knights whisper prayers to Seint Isabeau when they long to set aside their steel. Her shrine is a hawthorn grove where armour must be left at the gate. Pilgrims who enter bareskinned and speak a true regret find that their next wound heals in a single night but they dream of a woman in white who asks, "Will you remember how to be touched?" Those who return to the grove a second time are never seen again. The knights who survived Lence do not go near the grove. They are afraid of what they might forget or what they might remember.
- **Seint Evroul of the Cairn (Mor'iraath):** In the high passes of the Ethorian marches, a rusted knight in an unopened helm haunts the old barrows. He is the patron of those who carry a blooddebt and cannot rest. To call upon him, one must pour a cup of salt water at a cairn and name the wrong done to your house. He will witness one blow; if it lands, the foe is *Marked by the Cairn* any spirit may locate them for a year. If it misses, the blow turns inward. The MarshalExile carries a scar from such a bargain; he does not speak of it. He named the Fenwoods. The blow missed. He still does not understand why. The Cairn weeps rust.
- **The Order of the Sunken Cup (The Hospice of the Broken Blade):** A greyrobed hospice in the ruins of Lence treats the wounded of both crowns. They ask no payment, but they record every name in a ledger that never dries. The Restorationists suspect they are spies for the QueenMother; the Two Crowns accuse them of erasing debts. Sister Oria, the hospice's custodian, is also the keeper of the LanternRites House on the Belworth neutral ground where even claimants must leave their blades at the door. The ledger has a page for

every person who died at Lence. The page is still being written. The ink is still wet. The ink is made from ash and tears.

- **The Ninth:** In any Vhasian court, the ninth citation of precedent voids all previous. The wise stop at eight and settle. Those who cite the ninth are said to hear a faint laughter from the marble walls and their cases are never heard again. The laughter is the dead king’s. He was the ninth king of his line. He died at Lence. He is still laughing because the ninth citation is the only one that names the Fenwoods as the true heirs. No one has ever cited it. No one dares.

Vhasian Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Sun:** Crumble a crust onto a cracked sundisc. Ignore the first *Chevauchée* penalty. The sundisc should be from Lence. The older the crack, the better. The bread should be stale like the memory of the old king.
- **Knot the Seal:** Tie a single knot in a charter’s ribbon. Cancel *Parlement Divided* or take 1 die on your next legal argument (your choice). The ribbon should be black. Black is for mourning. The knot should be tied while facing east toward Lence.
- **Name to the Salt:** Whisper a dead claimant’s name into a salt pan. Gain +1 Effect when collecting debts from their faction this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the QueenMother. The salt pan should be on the Belworth. The dead claimant’s name should be spoken only once. The QueenMother will know. The salt will taste of ash.
- **The Lence Candle:** Light a candle in the ruins of Lence. For the next scene, any oath sworn by candlelight is binding but the candle will gutter if the oath is false. The dead will witness. They do not forgive. The candle should be made from the fat of a knight who died with his gorget buckled. There are many.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Rival officials or court guards take notice.
- **Noise:** Parlement clerks or routier patrols are alerted.
- **Trace:** Trackers or tax collectors mark your route.
- **Delay:** A setback costs time or a favourable legal window.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant resource clock.
- **Lence Echo:** A flash of smoke, a distant scream, a child’s face in a window. The memory of the sack surfaces. The GM gains 1 SB to spend on a fear effect. The fear is always the same: *that it will happen again*.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** A duchy constable or abbesschatelaine begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** Legal challenge or road closure costs you advantage.
- **Foe Appears:** A rival claimant or freecompany arrives.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes Compromised/Neglected.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test.

- **Claimant's Agent:** A spy working for Valdais, the QueenMother, or the Two Crowns reveals themselves. They demand a favour or a bribe. The bribe must be a memory of Lence. If you have none, they will take a finger.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional routiers, parlement guards, or ducal forces arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool or weapon becomes unusable.
- **Major Twist:** A writ is voided, an interdict declared, or a levy called.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark Fatigue 1/Harm 1 or an appropriate Condition.
- **The Dauphin's Name:** Someone speaks the child's name aloud. The QueenMother's spies are everywhere. The party is now on her radar. The child will dream of them.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates fully.
- **Authority Arrival:** The Two Crowns, QueenMother, or MarshalExile intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** A chevauchée hits, the river floods, or the parlement erupts.
- **Patron Omen:** An omen appears, a blessing is lost, or a curse manifests.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn.
- **The Sack Relived:** Smoke rises from Lence. The Fenwood banners appear on the horizon. It is a false alarm or is it? The party must test Resolve (DV 4) or lose 1d4 Fatigue from remembered terror. If they fail, they also gain the *Haunted* condition the dead of Lence will follow them for one session.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Fractured Authority:** Seals break midsigning, legal papers rewrite themselves, badges refuse honour.
- **Legal Warfare:** Court decisions reverse, precedents are cited against you, writs expire prematurely.
- **Sun Symbolism:** Sundiscs crack underfoot, light splits into contradictory shadows, oaths shatter like glass.
- **Lence's Shadow:** A ghost appears a soldier, a child, a king. It asks a question. Answering costs a memory. Refusing costs a curse. The question is always: *Why did you survive?*

Patronage & Power

In Vhasia, power flows through the remnants of imperial authority, fractured legitimacy, and the careful manipulation of legal and religious institutions. Former Utaran provincial structures still provide a framework for governance, but competing claimants to the Suncourt have created a complex web of overlapping jurisdictions and conflicting loyalties. The true power lies with those who can navigate this legal maze and maintain the appearance of legitimate authority.

But beneath the charters and the writs runs a deeper current: the memory of Lence. The Fenwood sack was not just a military defeat; it was a wound to the soul of Vhasia.

Every negotiation, every duel, every sealed document carries the weight of that loss. The QueenMother plays a long game, her Dauphin a card she may never play. Valdais wants the throne his father could not hold. The Two Crowns will accept any solution that leaves them richer. And the common folk—the farmers, the saltpanners, the road wardens—just want the raiding to stop.

They will wait. They have waited ten years. They can wait longer.

For the GM: Patronage in Vhasia revolves around legitimacy, legal documents, and the ability to command respect from institutions that no longer have a clear central authority. Rewards often take the form of charters, writs, and official positions that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize the postsack grief and the fragile peace:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, badges, writs) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided—especially if they bear the old king’s seal or the Fenwood mark.
- Let rival claimants issue conflicting authorities, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more—and whose memory of Lence they are willing to invoke.
- Use the parlements, cathedrals, and châteaux as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of law and custom determines success—and where the mere mention of the Fenwood name can shift the tide.
- Introduce the **Lence’s Shadow** mechanic: whenever a scene involves a legal dispute, a military maneuver, or a negotiation with a noble who lost family in the sack, the GM may spend 1 SB to invoke the memory of the burning. The Position worsens by one step, and the losing party may gain the *Haunted* condition.

In Vhasia, your papers are your power, and your power determines whether you rule or are ruled. But your memory of Lence—and how you use it—determines whether anyone will follow you.

The Vacant Throne & Campaign Clocks

For longform political campaigns:

- **Vacant Throne Clock [10]:** Advances when a claimant gains a major advantage (battle, noble defection, foreign alliance). Retreats when the party brokers a truce or exposes a weakness. When full, a claimant takes Lence and declares themselves king. The QueenMother will not live to see it. She will die the day the sun rises whole again.
- **Armor Closes [6]:** Advances when knights choose protection over mercy, when gorgets are buckled tight, when chivalry becomes siege mentality. When full, the cantons close their borders and the raids become wars. The Fenwoods taught Vhasia that mercy is a weakness. The knights have not forgotten. They sharpen their gorgets.
- **Song Escapes [8]:** Advances when a Cantor sings the truth, when mercy is shown, when armour is unbuckled. When full, a moment of genuine connection occurs—though it may be fatal. The Cantor Alain has been trying to fill this clock for ten years. He is still trying. He sings every dusk. The dead listen—and sometimes they answer.
- **Claimant’s Coup (per claimant):** A 6clock that advances when that claimant wins a Parlement vote, a joust, or a skirmish. When full, they march on Lence. The Dauphin—real or false—watches from the QueenMother’s keep. He does not know if he should cheer or weep.
- **Lence’s Reckoning [8]:** Tracks the party’s engagement with the memory of the sack. Advances when they aid a survivor, recover a relic, or speak the truth about what happened.

When full, a survivor reveals a secret: the old king's last words, the location of a hidden treasure, or the true parentage of the Dauphin. The secret will change the succession. It will also change the party. Some secrets are heavier than crowns.

Boss Seeds (threephase foes)

- **The Red Marshal (Exiled Suncourt hammer)** *Phases*: Chevauchee Call → Banner Turn → Lists to War. *Cracks*: Letters Patent buys one round of obedience; General Pardon lets a unit stand down. He was at Lence. He ran. He has not forgiven himself. He wears his gorget unbuckled.
- **Cardinal-Regent of the Broken Sun (scarlet gloves)** *Phases*: Interdict Blade → Seal Both Ways → Confessional Leak. *Cracks*: Queen's Audience cancels Interdict Blade once; a Synod Indulgence treats a church check as controlled for one scene. He was not at Lence. He blessed the Fenwood banners before they marched. He does not speak of it. His gloves are scarlet for a reason.
- **The Parlement Spider (chief clerk; quills like daggers)** *Phases*: Motion to Delay → CounterCitation → Filed at Dawn. *Cracks*: Sunburst Warrant opens a "royal window"; a Burgess Charter lets a town court overrule once locally. He keeps the lists. He knows which nobles voted for the Fenwood peace. He does not show the list to anyone. The list is written on his own skin.
- **The Two Crowns (rival dukes)** *Phases*: Contradictory Edicts → Levy in Hours → Coin Trial. *Cracks*: Sunburst Warrant + public mass unites them for one scene; General Pardon calms levy unrest once. They were not at Lence. They sent levies. The levies never returned. They pay the widows' pensions. They do not visit the graves. The graves visit them.
- **The QueenMother (Eliana Everblood)** *Phases*: Weave the Web → Unveil the Dauphin → The Sun Rises Again. *Cracks*: produce proof of the Dauphin's illegitimacy, convince Valdais to kneel, or find the old king's true heir (a child hidden in the Mistlands). She has outlived three husbands and two sons. She will outlive you. Her webs are woven from the hair of the dead.

Legendary Sites & Trials

- **Tournament Ordeal (Bastide Square)** Declare Purse, Patent, or Pardon as stakes. Win to cash a matching $\diamond$; lose and spawn *Tournament "Accident"*. The square was built on the site of a mass grave from Lence. The dead watch. They are not impartial. They vote with the wind.
- **Cathedral Scaffold Assize** Argue law atop creaking beams; each good point moves Position up; each slip marks Exposure. A *Paréage Charter* lets you call a recess once. The cathedral was rebuilt after the sack. The old stones are in the foundation. They still remember the fire. They also remember the screams.
- **Pont-du-Tithe Vigil** Keep the bridge peaceful through dusk: clear 3 segments on *Bridge Peace* by feeding pilgrims, quieting relic zeal, and paying one tithe from your purse. The bridge was the first structure the Fenwoods burned. The replacement stone was brought from Viterra. It still smells of smoke and of Veralyn's perfume. She was there.